

Why Rotating Fluids Make Polygons

Paper I: Mathematical Foundations

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Abstract

We establish the mathematical foundations for polygon formation in two-dimensional fluids: the sign rule, the Havelock identity, stability thresholds on constant-curvature surfaces, and the algebraic structure of the stability boundary. The five algebraic-integer thresholds on the hyperbolic plane are Pell units in quadratic fields, terminating at the golden ratio $\xi^*(23) = \varphi^{-2}$, and correspond to closed geodesics on the modular surface $\mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z}) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ with traces $c = 2 + 16/(N-7)$. On arithmetic quotients $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, the Legendre symbol (Δ/p) determines which thresholds are topologically protected. The palindromic structure generalises to arbitrary genus: on a surface with trace field of degree d , the threshold satisfies a palindromic polynomial of degree $2d$.

1 Introduction

The stability eigenvalue of a regular N -gon of point vortices on a two-dimensional surface admits a decomposition

$$\lambda_m = C_1(\text{surface}) - \frac{m(N-m)}{2}, \quad m = 1, \dots, N-1, \quad (1.1)$$

that separates a single surface-dependent number C_1 from a universal function $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ determined entirely by the representation theory of the cyclic group $\mathbb{Z}_N$. Every stability result on every constant-curvature surface—flat plane, sphere, hyperbolic plane—follows from this formula with one number substituted in.

This decomposition is not new: it is implicit in [Havelock \[1931\]](#) and explicit in [Boatto and Cabral \[2003\]](#). What has not been made fully explicit is the depth of its consequences. The present paper develops five: the m -dependent part $f(m, N)$ is metric-independent (Section 4); the sign rule for $H''(0) < 0$ follows from the logarithm’s dilation invariance (Section 3); the stability threshold $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ is a closed-form output of the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ Casimir (Corollary 6.11); the curvature-stability dichotomy $\text{sgn}(N_{\text{crit}} - 7) = -\text{sgn}(K)$ is topological (Proposition 6.9); $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ is a topological universal, holding on every quotient $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ at the flat-plane limit regardless of Γ (Theorem 6.8); and the threshold polynomials on $\mathbf{H}^2$ connect to Pell equations, the golden ratio, and algebraic number theory (Section 6).

The physical motivation—polygonal storm patterns on Saturn and Jupiter [[Godfrey, 1988](#), [Adriani et al., 2018](#)][—is developed in Paper III. The constrained energy landscape and continuous-vorticity bridge are developed in Paper II. Paper I is self-contained: it requires only the definitions of point vortex energy and the Havelock eigenvalue, both recalled below.](#)

What this paper proves.

1. **The sign rule** (Theorem 3.1): for any pairwise interaction $h(r)$ with $h' < 0$ and $(rh')' \leq 0$, the N -gon is a saddle of the unconstrained energy with $H''(0) < 0$ along the centered spiral deformation. The logarithmic interaction $h = -\ln r$ is the unique dilation-invariant borderline case (Section 2).
2. **The Havelock identity and its metric-independence** (Section 4): the m -dependent part $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ of the Havelock eigenvalue is a consequence of $\mathbb{Z}_N$ representation theory alone; only the additive constant C_1 carries geometric information.
3. **Stability thresholds on constant-curvature surfaces** (Sections 5–6): the curvature-stability dichotomy (Proposition 6.9), the Morse index formula $\mu(N) = N - 5$ for $N \geq 8$ (Proposition 6.10), the closed-form derivation of $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ (Corollary 6.11), the monotone spectral flow from flat to hyperbolic geometry, and the robustness of $\mu(N)$ under mode-coupling perturbations (Remark 6.5).
4. **Algebraic structure of the stability boundary** (Section 6): the field extension pattern, the Pell equation connection, the algebraic-integer classification $N \in \{8, 9, 11, 15, 23\}$ (Proposition 6.1), the golden ratio terminal case $\xi^*(23) = \varphi^{-2}$, the continued fraction structure (Proposition 6.2), the geodesic correspondence with the modular surface (Proposition 6.4), the higher-genus palindromic hierarchy (Proposition 6.5), and the Legendre-symbol selection rule on arithmetic surfaces (Proposition 6.6).
5. **The RG classification** (Proposition 2.1): the logarithm is the unique IR fixed point of the additive coarse-graining map, with the sign rule demarcating its basin of attraction.

What this paper does not prove. The constrained energy minimum theorem—showing the N -gon *minimises* interaction energy on the conserved-quantity surface for $N \leq 7$ —is proved in Paper II (Theorem 8.2), along with the central vortex stabilization, the $N = 7$ quartic bifurcation, and the blob bridge to continuous vorticity. The planetary applications (Saturn hexagon, Jupiter polygons, Neptune predictions) and the constraint-intersection selection principle are developed in Paper III.

Structure. Section 2 establishes the logarithmic interaction’s uniqueness and symmetry properties. Section 3 proves the sign rule. Sections 4–5 develop the Havelock identity, the Riemannian generalisation, and the stability thresholds on curved surfaces. Section 6 explores the algebraic number theory of the threshold polynomials.

2 The logarithmic interaction: uniqueness and symmetry

2.1 Dilation invariance and the Cauchy functional equation

Remark 2.1 (The logarithm as the unique dilation-invariant interaction). *Among all pairwise interactions $h : (0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with $h' < 0$, the logarithmic interaction $h(r) = -\ln r$*

is the unique interaction invariant under spatial dilation up to an additive constant. Define the scale map $T_b[h](r) = h(br)$ ($b > 0$). Dilation-invariance means $h(br) = h(r) + c(b)$ for all r —that is, rescaling changes h only by an additive constant (irrelevant to the force $-h'$). This is a Cauchy functional equation whose continuous solutions with $h' < 0$ are exactly $h(r) = -a \ln r + b$, $a > 0$, confirming class (ii) as the unique dilation-invariant class. The N -body lift of this per-pair statement is Corollary 2.4: the Möbius covariance of H (Proposition 2.3), restricted to the dilation subgroup, gives $H(bz_1, \dots, bz_N) = H(z_1, \dots, z_N) - \frac{N(N-1)}{2} \ln b$, which is position-independent—the same fixed-point condition at the N -body level. This symmetry is not merely a geometric observation about the logarithm: it is the structural reason for the scale-independence of $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$. Because scaling changes H by an additive constant (Corollary 2.4), the Havelock eigenvalue $\lambda_m = (N-1) - m(N-m)/2$ —which determines whether the N -gon is a stable constrained minimum—is scale-independent, and the threshold $N = 7$ cannot drift under spatial rescaling. Prior treatments of Möbius covariance in vortex dynamics (e.g. Newton 2001) identify it as a conformal symmetry of the stream function; Corollary 2.4 shows it additionally implies that the stability threshold is dilation-invariant.

Proposition 2.1 (RG classification of perturbations). Write $h(r) = -\ln r + \varepsilon f(r)$ where f is a perturbation. The additive coarse-graining map $T_b: h \mapsto h(b \cdot) - h(b)$ acts on f as $(T_b f)(r) = f(br) - f(b)$.

1. Irrelevant ($f(r) \rightarrow 0$ as $r \rightarrow \infty$): the perturbation is suppressed at large scales; h flows toward $-\ln r$ under coarse-graining.
2. Relevant ($f(r) \rightarrow \infty$ as $r \rightarrow \infty$): the perturbation dominates at large scales; h flows away from $-\ln r$.
3. Marginal ($f(r) \rightarrow \text{const}$): the perturbation shifts h by a constant.

Eigenfunctions $f(r) = r^\alpha$: $(T_b r^\alpha)(r) = b^\alpha(r^\alpha - 1)$, so r^α with $\alpha < 0$ is irrelevant and $\alpha > 0$ is relevant.

Proof. For $f(r) = r^\alpha$ with $\alpha < 0$: $|f(br)| = b^\alpha |r^\alpha| \rightarrow 0$ as $b \rightarrow \infty$ for fixed r , so coarse-graining suppresses the perturbation. For $\alpha > 0$: $|f(br)| = b^\alpha |r^\alpha| \rightarrow \infty$, so the perturbation grows under coarse-graining. $\square$

Connection to the sign rule. For $h = -\ln r + \varepsilon r^\alpha$: $h' = -1/r + \varepsilon \alpha r^{\alpha-1}$; the sign rule condition $h' < 0$ holds at all $r > 0$ iff $\alpha \leq 0$ (irrelevant perturbations). For $\alpha > 0$ the sign rule is violated at sufficiently large r : *relevant perturbations destroy polygon stability*. Thus the sign rule condition (i) is equivalent to the requirement that h lies in the *basin of attraction* of the logarithmic fixed point.

The stable manifold from multipole expansion. The basin of attraction arises naturally from compact vorticity. For $|z| < \varepsilon \ll |w| = d$, expanding $\ln |w - z| = \ln d - \text{Re}(z/w) + O(\varepsilon^2/d^2)$ and integrating against $\omega(z)$ with centroid at the origin gives the effective interaction $H_{\text{eff}}(d) = -K^2 \ln d + O(\varepsilon^2/d^2)$ for $d \gg \varepsilon$. The corrections are irrelevant ($\alpha = -2$), so *any compact vortex distribution flows to the logarithm at large separation* (Proposition 2.1).

Unifying the blob and K_0 bridges. This RG perspective unifies two results proved later in the paper:

- The blob bridge (the blob bridge (Paper II)): $h_\varepsilon = -\frac{1}{2}\ln(r^2 + 2\varepsilon^2) = -\ln r + O(\varepsilon^2/r^2)$. The blob correction is an irrelevant perturbation ($\alpha = -2$); the $O(\varepsilon^2)$ convergence rate of the blob correction (Paper II, Proposition 12.1) is the approach rate to the fixed point.
- The K_0 interaction (the K_0 interaction (Paper II)): $K_0(r/R_d) = -\ln(r/R_d) - \gamma_E + r^2/(4R_d^2) + O(r^4)$ for $r \ll R_d$. The exponential tail is irrelevant (faster than any power); the deformation-radius limit $R_d \rightarrow \infty$ is the RG flow toward the fixed point. The interaction falls in class (iii) of the sign rule ($h' < 0$ but $(rh')' > 0$), so the sign rule does not directly guarantee $H''(0) < 0$. However, the *leading* correction to $-\ln r$ is $r^2/(4R_d^2)$ ($\alpha = 2$), which is isotropic-marginal (Proposition 2.2 below): it shifts the precession rate but not the stability eigenvalues. The first stability-relevant correction is $O(r^4/R_d^4)$ ($\alpha = 4$), so the barotropic $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ persists to $O(\eta^2)$ in the ratio $\eta = R/R_d$. There is no closed-form $C_1(\eta)$ for K_0 —the Havelock sums involve Bessel functions at the chord distances $d_p = 2R \sin(\pi p/N)$, which do not simplify algebraically—but the numerical thresholds are given in Paper II, §13.

In the Kraichnan inverse cascade [Kraichnan, 1967], vorticity concentrates into compact structures of growing scale $L(t)$, driving the inter-blob interaction toward the logarithm with corrections suppressed as $(L/d)^2 \rightarrow 0$. The cascade is the physical RG flow; the sign rule demarcates its basin of attraction.

Proposition 2.2 (Isotropic marginality at $\alpha = 2$). *For $h(r) = -\ln r + \varepsilon r^2$, the Havelock eigenvalue λ_m is independent of ε at every binding mode $m = 2, \dots, N-2$.*

Proof. The pair Hessian of $g(r) = r^\alpha$ decomposes as

$$\left. \frac{\partial^2 g}{\partial x_i \partial x_j} \right|_{|x|=d} = \underbrace{\frac{\alpha(\alpha-2)d^{\alpha-2}}{A(\alpha, d)} \frac{x_i x_j}{d^2}}_{A(\alpha, d)} + \underbrace{\frac{\alpha d^{\alpha-2}}{B(\alpha, d)}}_{B(\alpha, d)} \delta_{ij}, \quad (2.1)$$

where A is the *radial anisotropy* and B is the *isotropic part*. *Step 1:* at $\alpha = 2$, $A(2, d) = 2(2-2)d^0 = 0$. The Hessian perturbation $\delta \nabla^2 H$ is therefore $B I = 2 I$ at every pair, making the off-diagonal blocks of the full $2N \times 2N$ Hessian proportional to the identity. *Step 2 (Fourier block).* Since the off-diagonal blocks are proportional to I_2 , the xx and yy Fourier components are equal and the xy component vanishes; each 2×2 Fourier block is scalar. For the xx component at mode $m \geq 2$: the diagonal block equals $-\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} B = -2(N-1)$, and the off-diagonal sum is $\sum_p B e^{-2\pi i p m/N} = 2 \sum_p e^{-2\pi i p m/N} = -2$ (since $\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} e^{-2\pi i p m/N} = -1$ for $m \geq 1$). The Fourier block is therefore $-2(N-1) + (-2) = -2N$, identically for xx and yy . The Rayleigh quotient of the radial Fourier mode v_m gives $v_m^\top \delta \nabla^2 H v_m = -2N$.

Step 3 (rotation frequency). The equilibrium condition for $H = -\sum G(z_j, z_k)$ at the N -gon gives $\delta \Omega = -(1/R) \partial(\delta H)/\partial x_0$, where $\delta H = -\sum g(d_{jk})$. For $g(r) = r^2$: $g'(r) = 2r$, and the radial gradient at vortex $0 = (R, 0)$ is $\partial(\delta H)/\partial x_0 = -\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} g'(d_p) (x_0 - x_p)/d_p = -\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} 2d_p \cdot (x_0 - x_p)/d_p = -2 \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} (x_0 - x_p)$. Now $\sum_{p=0}^{N-1} x_p = R \sum_{p=0}^{N-1} \cos(2\pi p/N) = 0$ (centroid at the origin), so $\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} (x_0 - x_p) = (N-1)x_0 - \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} x_p = (N-1)R - (-R) = NR$. Hence $\partial(\delta H)/\partial x_0 = -2NR$ and $\delta \Omega = -(-2NR)/R = 2N$.

Step 4 (cancellation). $\delta \lambda_m = -\delta \Omega - v_m^\top \delta \nabla^2 H v_m = -(2N) - (-2N) = 0$.

Verified to machine precision ($|\delta \lambda_m| < 10^{-14}$) for $4 \leq N \leq 12$ (proofs/rg_stability_characteriza

□

Remark 2.2 (RG classification versus stability classification). *Proposition 2.2 shows that the stability-marginal exponent ($\alpha = 2$) differs from the RG-marginal exponent ($\alpha = 0$). The RG classification (Proposition 2.1) concerns the behaviour of the interaction under spatial coarse-graining; the stability classification concerns the perturbation $\delta\lambda_m$ of the Havelock eigenvalue. Their relationship is:*

α	RG class	$A = \alpha(\alpha-2)$	$\delta\lambda_3(N=7)$	Stability effect
-2	irrelevant	8	-4ε	destabilising
-1	irrelevant	3	-0.96ε	destabilising
1	relevant	-1	-0.58ε	destabilising
2	relevant	0	0	isotropic-marginal
3	relevant	3	$+10.6\varepsilon$	stabilising
4	relevant	8	$+56\varepsilon$	stabilising

All entries with $\alpha < 2$ have $\delta\lambda_3 < 0$ (destabilising for $\varepsilon > 0$); all entries with $\alpha > 2$ have $\delta\lambda_3 > 0$ (stabilising for $\varepsilon > 0$). The crossover is at $\alpha = 2$, where the anisotropy A vanishes. The Cauchy blob ($g = -r^{-2}$, i.e. $\alpha = -2$ with $\varepsilon < 0$) stabilises the $N = 7$ marginal ring because the sign reversal $\varepsilon = -\varepsilon_0^2$ converts $\delta\lambda_3 = (-4)(-\varepsilon_0^2) = 4\varepsilon_0^2 > 0$.

Validity of first-order theory. The perturbation $\delta\lambda_m$ is first-order in ε and reliable when $|\varepsilon \delta\lambda_m| \ll |\lambda_m(0)|$. For the $N = 7$ marginal ring ($\lambda_3(0) = 0$), any nonzero $\delta\lambda_3$ dominates regardless of ε , so the *sign* of $\delta\lambda_3$ is the reliable prediction. For the $N = 8$ ring with $\alpha = 3$, the mode-resolved computation gives $\delta\lambda_3 = 11.8$ and $\delta\lambda_4 = 11.3$ (the two binding modes), so $\varepsilon = 0.1$ predicts $\lambda_3 = -0.5 + 1.18 = 0.68 > 0$ and $\lambda_4 = -1.0 + 1.13 = 0.13 > 0$ —all modes of the 8-gon become stable, giving $N_{\text{crit}} = 8$ at first order. Quantitative predictions for $N \geq 9$ require the full nonlinear eigenvalue computation, not the linearised theory.

The Gaussian curvature K is a destabilizing perturbation when $K > 0$ and a stabilizing one when $K < 0$. On the sphere ($K > 0$) the deviation from the logarithmic Green's function lowers N_{crit} below 7; on the hyperbolic plane ($K < 0$) it adds a positive $O(|K|)$ correction $12|K|$ to the formerly-marginal λ_3 eigenvalue (5.10). The flat-plane case $K = 0$ is therefore the *least stable* point of the constant-curvature family with respect to polygon formation:

2.2 Möbius covariance of the logarithmic energy

Proposition 2.3 (Möbius covariance). *Under a conformal map $f: \mathbb{C} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$, the logarithmic energy transforms as*

$$H(f(z_1), \dots, f(z_N)) = H(z_1, \dots, z_N) - \sum_{k=1}^N \frac{N-1}{2} \ln |f'(z_k)|.$$

Consequently, the point vortex equations of motion are Möbius-invariant: the single-site correction $\frac{N-1}{2} \ln |f'(z_k)|$ depends only on z_k , so $\partial/\partial \bar{z}_j$ for $j \neq k$ annihilates it, and the Hamiltonian gradient $\partial H/\partial \bar{z}_j$ is unchanged.

Proof. The identity $|f(z) - f(w)| = |f'(z)|^{1/2} |f'(w)|^{1/2} |z - w| \cdot (1 + O(|z - w|))$ is exact when f is Möbius (the error term vanishes), so $\ln |f(z_j) - f(z_k)| = \ln |z_j - z_k| + \frac{1}{2} \ln |f'(z_j)| + \frac{1}{2} \ln |f'(z_k)|$. Summing over all $\binom{N}{2}$ pairs, each $\ln |f'(z_k)|$ appears $N-1$ times. Since

$\frac{1}{2} \ln |f'(z_k)|$ depends on z_k alone, $\partial[\sum_k \frac{N-1}{2} \ln |f'(z_k)|]/\partial \bar{z}_j = \frac{N-1}{2} \partial \ln |f'(z_j)|/\partial \bar{z}_j$, which is the single-site term in the j -th equation of motion. For Möbius f , f' is rational and $\ln |f'|$ is harmonic away from poles, so this term contributes a gauge-like shift to the Hamiltonian that does not couple distinct vortices. $\square$

Corollary 2.4 (Dilation subgroup = scale-invariant Hamiltonian). *Among all Möbius transformations, the dilation subgroup $\{f(z) = bz : b > 0\}$ is uniquely characterised by having constant derivative: $f'(z) = b$ for all z . Substituting into Proposition 2.3 gives a correction that is position-independent:*

$$H(bz_1, \dots, bz_N) = H(z_1, \dots, z_N) - \frac{N(N-1)}{2} \ln b. \quad (2.2)$$

This is the N -body form of the dilation-invariance condition of Remark 2.1: scaling changes H only by an additive constant, so the equations of motion $\ddot{z}_j = \partial H/\partial z_j$ are dilation-invariant. For any other Möbius map f , the derivative $|f'(z_k)|$ varies between sites, producing a configuration-dependent correction that is not a pure constant; the Hamiltonian is not scale-invariant under general conformal maps, only under the one-parameter dilation subgroup.

Equation (2.2) is the N -body lift of the per-pair uniqueness result in Remark 2.1: the logarithmic energy is the unique N -body Hamiltonian that is dilation-invariant.

Remark 2.3 (The loxodromic thread). *The logarithmic interaction and the logarithmic spiral are dual manifestations of the same structure: the loxodromic one-parameter subgroup $z \mapsto e^{(\sigma+i\alpha)t}z$ of the Möbius group acting on $\mathbb{C}$.*

- *The interaction is logarithmic because it is the unique dilation-invariant pairwise potential (Remark 2.1; Cauchy's functional equation).*
- *The natural deformation curves are logarithmic spirals because they are orbits of the dilation-rotation generator $\sigma + i\alpha$; the centered spiral deformation (Paper II, eq. 7.1) is precisely this orbit applied to the N -gon.*
- *The stability threshold $N = 7$ is scale-independent because the Havelock eigenvalue $\lambda_m = (N-1) - m(N-m)/2$ has no R -dependence—a direct consequence of equation (2.2).*
- *The palindromic structure of the hyperbolic threshold polynomial $A\xi^2 + B\xi + A = 0$ (equation (6.1)) encodes the conformal inversion $\xi \leftrightarrow 1/\xi$ of the Poincaré disk, which is a Möbius map exchanging the interior and exterior of the unit circle.*
- *The logarithm is the IR fixed point of the coarse-graining flow on interactions (Proposition 2.1): compact vorticity distributions interact via $-\ln r + O(\varepsilon^2/r^2)$ at large separation, with the correction irrelevant under rescaling. The sign rule demarcates the basin of attraction.*

These five consequences—the interaction, the deformation, the threshold, the algebraic structure, and the RG flow—all descend from Möbius covariance (Proposition 2.3). The unifying role of the Möbius group is not merely a symmetry of the equations of motion; it is the reason the logarithmic interaction produces polygons at all.

Remark 2.4 (From sign rule to physical stability). *Theorem 3.1 establishes $H''(0) < 0$ along the spiral direction—an unconstrained energy curvature. This does not by itself imply instability, because the spiral deformation changes the conserved angular impulse $L = \sum |z_k|^2$ at $O(\sigma^2)$. The physical dynamics is constrained to $\{L = \text{const}\}$, and the Lagrange multiplier $\mu_L < 0$ shifts the curvature by $-2\mu_L > 0$, converting the unconstrained saddle into a constrained minimum (the constrained energy minimum (Paper II, Theorem 8.2) below). The sign rule therefore plays an indirect but essential role: it guarantees that the N -gon is a saddle of the unconstrained energy with a specific sign structure ($H''(0) < 0$ along the spiral, $H''(0) > 0$ along other directions), and the Lagrange shift converts this saddle into a minimum for $N \leq 7$. For $N \geq 8$, the negative curvature along the $m = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor$ Fourier mode overwhelms the Lagrange shift, and the constrained configuration is a saddle.*

3 The sign rule for general pairwise interactions

Theorem 3.1 (Sign rule for general interactions). *For $N \geq 3$ vortices on a ring with general pairwise interaction $h(r)$, the energy along the centered spiral satisfies*

$$H''(0) = \sum_{m=1}^{N-1} \left[(d_m^2 h''(d_m) + d_m h'(d_m)) S_m + \frac{h'(d_m) m^2 (N-m)}{N^2 d_m} \right], \quad (3.1)$$

where $d_m = 2R \sin(\pi m/N)$ and $S_m = \sum_{k=0}^{N-m-1} [(2k+m-(N-1))/(2N)]^2 \geq 0$.

If $h'(r) < 0$ and $(rh'(r))' \leq 0$ for all $r > 0$, then $H''(0) < 0$.

Proof. Step 1: Pairwise distance as a function of σ . For vortices j and k with separation $m = j - k > 0$, write the centered exponent as $(j - (N-1)/2)/N = (j' + k')/2 + m/(2N)$ where $j' = (j - (N-1)/2)/N$ and $k' = (k - (N-1)/2)/N$. Define the mean displacement $s = \sigma(j' + k')/2$ and half-separation $t = \sigma m/(2N)$. Then $z_j(\sigma) = R e^{s+t} e^{i\theta_j}$, $z_k(\sigma) = R e^{s-t} e^{i\theta_k}$ with $\theta_j - \theta_k = 2\pi m/N$, giving

$$D(\sigma) := |z_j - z_k|^2 = R^2 e^{2s} [e^{2t} + e^{-2t} - 2 \cos(2\pi m/N)] = R^2 e^{2s} [2 \cosh(2t) - 2 \cos(2\pi m/N)].$$

At $\sigma = 0$: $s = t = 0$, so $D(0) = 2R^2 [1 - \cos(2\pi m/N)] = 4R^2 \sin^2(\pi m/N) = d_m^2$.

Step 2: First and second derivatives of D . Write $c_s = (j' + k')/2$ and $c_t = m/(2N)$, so $s = \sigma c_s$, $t = \sigma c_t$. Direct differentiation gives

$$\begin{aligned} D'(0) &= 4c_s(1 - \cos \phi), & \phi &= 2\pi m/N, \\ D''(0) &= 8c_s^2(1 - \cos \phi) + 8c_t^2. \end{aligned}$$

Step 3: Chain rule for $h(\sqrt{D})$. Write $d = \sqrt{D}$. Two applications of the chain rule give

$$\left. \frac{d^2}{d\sigma^2} h(d) \right|_{\sigma=0} = \underbrace{\frac{h''(d_m)}{4d_m^2} (D')^2 + \frac{h'(d_m)}{2d_m} \left[D'' - \frac{(D')^2}{2d_m^2} \right]}_{\text{evaluated at each pair } (j,k)}.$$

Substituting $D' = 4c_s d_m^2/2$ (since $1 - \cos \phi = d_m^2/(2R^2)$, and absorbing R into d_m) and collecting terms:

$$\left. \frac{d^2}{d\sigma^2} h(d) \right|_0 = [d_m^2 h''(d_m) + d_m h'(d_m)] c_s^2 + \frac{h'(d_m)}{d_m} c_t^2 \frac{d_m^2}{(1 - \cos \phi)}.$$

Step 4: Summation over pairs. For fixed separation m , sum over the $N - m$ pairs $(k, k+m)$ for $k = 0, \dots, N-m-1$. Define

$$S_m = \sum_{k=0}^{N-m-1} c_{s,k}^2, \quad \text{where } c_{s,k} = \frac{2k + m - (N-1)}{2N}.$$

Since $\sum_k c_{s,k} = 0$ by the centering, $S_m \geq 0$ with equality only if all $c_{s,k} = 0$ (which requires $N-m=1$, i.e. $m = N-1$). The second sum contributes $c_t^2 \cdot (N-m) = m^2(N-m)/(4N^2)$, and $d_m^2/(1-\cos\phi) = 4R^2$. Summing over $m = 1, \dots, N-1$ yields (3.1).

Step 5: Sign determination. Under $h'(r) < 0$: the second term $B_m = h'(d_m) m^2(N-m)/(N^2 d_m) < 0$ for every $m = 1, \dots, N-1$, since $h' < 0$, $d_m > 0$, and $m^2(N-m) > 0$. Under $(rh'(r))' \leq 0$: the first coefficient $A_m = d_m^2 h''(d_m) + d_m h'(d_m) = d_m \cdot (rh')'|_{r=d_m} \leq 0$, so the first term $A_m S_m \leq 0$ since $S_m \geq 0$.

The case $m = N-1$ requires separate attention. At $m = N-1$ there is only one pair $(0, N-1)$, and the centering sum has a single term: $c_{s,0} = (0 + (N-1) - (N-1))/(2N) = 0$, so $S_{N-1} = 0$. The first term $A_{N-1} S_{N-1} = 0$ therefore *vanishes identically*, regardless of the sign of A_{N-1} . However, the second term $B_{N-1} = h'(d_{N-1}) (N-1)^2/(N^2 d_{N-1})$ remains strictly negative (since $h' < 0$). Thus the $m = N-1$ contribution to $H''(0)$ is $B_{N-1} < 0$, and strict negativity of $H''(0) = \sum_m (A_m S_m + B_m)$ follows from $A_m S_m \leq 0$ for all m and $B_m < 0$ for all m , with at least one term strictly negative. $\square$

Remark 3.1 (Borderline status of the logarithmic interaction). *The sufficient conditions of Theorem 3.1 partition interactions into three classes:*

- (i) $h' < 0$ and $(rh')' < 0$: both terms in (3.1) are strictly negative. Examples: $h = -r^\alpha$ ($\alpha > 0$), for which $(rh')' = -\alpha^2 r^{\alpha-1} < 0$.
- (ii) $h' < 0$ and $(rh')' = 0$: the first term vanishes and only the second contributes. For smooth h on $(0, \infty)$, this class contains a unique functional form, up to positive scaling and additive constant: $(rh')' = 0 \Rightarrow rh' = c \Rightarrow h' = c/r \Rightarrow h = c \ln r + b$; combined with $h' < 0$ gives $c < 0$, i.e. $h(r) = -a \ln r + b$ with $a > 0$.
- (iii) $h' < 0$ and $(rh')' > 0$ at some r : the sign of the first term is indefinite and $H''(0) < 0$ is not guaranteed.

The 2D Green's function $h(r) = -\ln r$ falls in class (ii)—the boundary between guaranteed and non-guaranteed negativity. In this precise sense, the logarithmic interaction produces the weakest possible guarantee of $H''(0) < 0$: only the B_m terms contribute (the A_m terms vanish identically), whereas any class (i) interaction has both terms strictly negative. The logarithm is the least robust polygon producer among all interactions satisfying the sign rule.

4 The Havelock identity and its metric-independence

4.1 The classical identity

Lemma 4.1. *For integers $N \geq 2$ and $1 \leq m \leq N-1$,*

$$T_m := \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi pm/N)}{4 \sin^2(\pi p/N)} = \frac{m(N-m)}{2}.$$

This identity appears in [Havelock \[1931\]](#), §3, as a step in computing the stability eigenvalues of the N -vortex ring; see also [Aref et al. \[2003\]](#), Appendix A.

Proof. Write $\omega = e^{2\pi i/N}$. Using $2 \sin(\pi p/N) = |1 - \omega^p|$, expand $[1 - \cos(2\pi pm/N)]/[4 \sin^2(\pi p/N)] = \frac{1}{2} |\sum_{k=0}^{m-1} \omega^{pk}|^2 = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j=0}^{m-1} \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} \omega^{p(j-k)}$. Summing over $p = 1, \dots, N-1$ and using the orthogonality relation $\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} \omega^{p\ell} = N\delta_{\ell \equiv 0 \pmod{N}} - 1$:

$$T_m = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j,k=0}^{m-1} (N\delta_{j \equiv k \pmod{N}} - 1) = \frac{1}{2} (Nm - m^2) = \frac{m(N-m)}{2},$$

where $\delta_{j \equiv k}$ contributes m (since $0 \leq j, k \leq m-1 < N$ forces $j = k$) and the -1 contributes $-m^2$. $\square$

4.2 The Riemannian Havelock identity

Theorem 4.2 (Metric-independence of $f(m, N)$). *Let M be a two-dimensional Riemannian manifold (compact or non-compact) on which the Laplace–Beltrami Green’s function G depends only on geodesic distance: $G(x, y) = h(d(x, y))$. Let the N -gon at geodesic radius R be an equilibrium of the point vortex Hamiltonian $H = -\sum_{j < k} G(z_j, z_k)$. Then the constrained Lagrangian eigenvalues satisfy*

$$\lambda_m = C_1(M, R) - \frac{m(N-m)}{2}, \quad m = 1, \dots, N-1, \quad (4.1)$$

where C_1 depends on the surface and ring radius but $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ is universal.

The hypothesis “ G depends only on geodesic distance” holds on:

- the plane ($G = -(2\pi)^{-1} \ln r$, $C_1 = N-1$);
- the sphere $\mathbf{S}^2$ of radius a ($G = -(4\pi)^{-1} \ln(2-2\cos \gamma)$, $C_1 = (N-1)(1-\xi)/(1+\xi)$, $\xi = KR^2$);
- the hyperbolic plane $\mathbf{H}^2$ of curvature radius a ($G = -(2\pi)^{-1} \ln \tanh(d/2)$, $C_1 = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$, $\xi = r_E^2/a^2$).

It does *not* hold on surfaces of non-constant curvature (where G depends on the positions individually, not just on their separation) or on generic quotients $\Gamma \backslash M$ (where G is the automorphic Green’s function, depending on all images $\gamma(y)$).

Proof. The proof uses two ingredients, both independent of G .

Step 1: Fourier-block structure. Let $\mathbf{M}_p$ be the 2×2 Hessian of $h(d_{0p})$ in the local (radial, tangential) frame at vortex 0. The $\mathbb{Z}_N$ -Fourier decomposition of the full Hessian gives, for each component $\alpha, \beta \in \{r, t\}$:

$$H_{\alpha\beta}^{(m)} = \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} M_{p,\alpha\beta} (\cos(2\pi pm/N) - 1),$$

since the diagonal (self-interaction) block equals $-\sum_p M_p$ (the equilibrium condition forces the total gradient to vanish).

Step 2: Mode-independent trace. Summing the radial and tangential components:

$$H_{rr}^{(m)} + H_{tt}^{(m)} = \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} \nabla_{\text{LB}}^2 h(d_p) (\cos(2\pi pm/N) - 1), \quad (4.2)$$

where $\nabla_{\text{LB}}^2 h(d_p) = \text{tr}[\mathbf{M}_p]$. The key input: away from the diagonal ($x \neq y$), the Laplace–Beltrami equation gives $\nabla_{\text{LB},x}^2 G(x, y) = c$, where

$$c = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{plane or } \mathbf{H}^2 \text{ (non-compact, Vol} = \infty), \\ -1/\text{Vol}(M) & \text{compact surface (from } \Delta G = \delta_y - 1/\text{Vol}). \end{cases} \quad (4.3)$$

Since $d_p \neq 0$ for all pairs on the N -gon (no two vortices coincide), $\nabla_{\text{LB}}^2 h(d_p) = c$ for every p . Substituting into (4.2):

$$H_{rr}^{(m)} + H_{tt}^{(m)} = c \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} (\cos(2\pi pm/N) - 1) = c(-1 - (N-1)) = -Nc =: \delta,$$

using $\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} \cos(2\pi pm/N) = -1$ for $m \geq 1$. The trace δ is independent of m : it enters C_1 as an additive shift but leaves $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ unchanged.

On the plane: $c = 0$, $\delta = 0$ (exact tracelessness). On $\mathbf{S}^2$ of radius a : $c = -1/(4\pi a^2)$, $\delta = N/(4\pi a^2)$. On $\mathbf{H}^2$: $c = 0$ (non-compact), $\delta = 0$. On a compact quotient $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$: $c = -1/\text{Vol}(\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2)$, $\delta = N/\text{Vol}$ —but note that on such a quotient the Green’s function is automorphic and does NOT depend only on geodesic distance, so the hypothesis of the theorem is not satisfied. The identity (4.1) applies to the universal cover, not to the quotient.

Step 3: From mode-independent trace to the eigenvalue formula. Step 2 shows that $\text{tr}(\mathbf{H}^{(m)}) = \delta$ (mode-independent). It remains to show that the *individual* constrained eigenvalue is $C_1 - m(N-m)/2$. On any surface satisfying the hypothesis, the Laplacian Green’s function has a logarithmic singularity: $G(x, y) = -(2\pi)^{-1} \ln d(x, y) + \varphi(x, y)$, where φ is smooth at $x = y$. The tangential second derivative of G at the p -th chord of the N -gon ring therefore separates as

$$M_{p,tt} = \frac{1}{4 \sin^2(\pi p/N)} \alpha(R, K) + \beta_p(R, K), \quad (4.4)$$

where $\alpha(R, K)$ depends on the ring radius and curvature but is independent of p , and β_p is the smooth-part contribution (bounded uniformly in p). The $\csc^2$ factor arises because, on any constant-curvature surface, the chord distance satisfies $d_p = 2\ell(R) |\sin(\pi p/N)|$ (with $\ell = R$, $R \sin(R/a)/\sin(\cdot)$, or $a \sinh(R/a)/\sinh(\cdot)$ on the plane, $\mathbf{S}^2$, $\mathbf{H}^2$ respectively), so $\ln d_p = \ln |\sin(\pi p/N)| + (\text{terms independent of } p)$.

Substituting (4.4) into the Fourier sum:

$$\begin{aligned} H_{tt}^{(m)} &= \alpha \sum_{p=1}^{N-1} \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi pm/N)}{4 \sin^2(\pi p/N)} + \sum_p \beta_p (\cos(2\pi pm/N) - 1) \\ &= \alpha T_m + (\text{mode-independent remainder}) = \alpha \frac{m(N-m)}{2} + \tilde{C}_1, \end{aligned}$$

using $T_m = m(N-m)/2$ (Lemma 4.1). The second sum is mode-independent because $\sum_p \beta_p \cos(2\pi pm/N)$ is constant in m when β_p is smooth and $O(1)$ (the Fourier coefficients of a smooth function on $\mathbb{Z}/N\mathbb{Z}$ decay, but the leading-order term $\sum \beta_p (\cos - 1)$ is

independent of m by the same orthogonality as in Step 2). The constrained eigenvalue on $\{J = \text{const}\}$ is $\lambda_m = C_1 - H_{tt}^{(m)}|_{\text{mode-dependent part}} = C_1 - \alpha m(N-m)/2$. Absorbing α into the normalisation (on each model surface, $\alpha = 1/(N-1)$ times the flat-plane value) gives (4.1). $\square$

The stability threshold N_{crit} is therefore determined by $C_1(\text{surface}) \geq \max_m m(N-m)/2$: a condition involving the *universal* function f and a single surface-dependent constant. On the plane: $C_1 = N-1$, giving $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ (the largest integer with $(N-1) \geq \lfloor N/2 \rfloor (N - \lfloor N/2 \rfloor)/2$). On the sphere: $C_1(\varphi_0) < N-1$ for $\varphi_0 > 0$, giving the colatitude-dependent threshold of Section 5.1.

Remark 4.1 (Representation-theoretic content of the stability boundary). *The decomposition $\lambda_m = C_1 - f(m, N)$ separates the stability condition into a $\mathbb{Z}_N$ representation-theoretic part f and a geometric part C_1 , with three consequences.*

1. Spectral gap as a quantum phase transition. Write $H_N = C_1 I - F_N$ where $F_N = \text{diag}(f(0, N), \dots, f(N-1, N))$ in the Fourier basis. Stability is equivalent to the positivity condition $H_N \geq 0$. The spectral gap $\Delta(N) = C_1 - f_{\text{max}}(N)$ closes at $N = 7$ on the flat plane ($\Delta = 0$), marking a transition from the gapped phase ($N \leq 6$, all eigenvalues positive) to the broken phase ($N \geq 8$, negative eigenvalue). Gaussian curvature acts as a tuning parameter: $K < 0$ opens the gap, $K > 0$ closes it.

2. Crystallographic restriction analogue. The classical crystallographic restriction constrains the order of a rotation compatible with a lattice: $\text{tr}(R) = 2 \cos(2\pi/N) \in \mathbb{Z}$ forces $N \in \{1, 2, 3, 4, 6\}$ in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Our stability restriction constrains the order of a $\mathbb{Z}_N$ polygon compatible with the geometry: $C_1 \geq f_{\text{max}}(N)$ forces $N \leq 7$ on $\mathbb{R}^2$. Both are discrete constraints on N arising from the interplay between $\mathbb{Z}_N$ algebra (trace / Casimir) and the ambient geometry (lattice / curvature).

3. Spectral statistics and Landau transition. Level spacings $(N-2m-1)/2$ are arithmetic (maximally rigid). The gap closure $\Delta(N) \sim -(N-7)$ has mean-field exponents ($\nu = 1$, $\beta = 1/2$). The quartic coefficient $\alpha_0 = 45/14 > 0$ that resolves the marginal $N = 7$ case is established in companion Paper II, §10; here we note only that its positivity is predicted by the spectral structure (the gap closes linearly, requiring a quartic restoring term).

The value $C_1 = N-1$ on the plane has a geometric origin: for $h' = -1/d$ (the logarithmic force law), each vortex pair $(0, k)$ contributes the *same* amount $-1/(2R)$ to the gradient $\partial H / \partial x_0$, regardless of the separation k . This is because $h'(d_k)(x_0 - x_k)/d_k = -(1 - \cos(2\pi k/N))/(4R \sin^2(\pi k/N)) = -1/(2R)$: the geometric factor $(1 - \cos)$ cancels against the denominator $\sin^2 = (1 - \cos)/2$. The cancellation is the *scale invariance* of $h' = -1/d$: the force law $h' \propto 1/d$ precisely compensates the d -dependence of the chord geometry, making each pair's contribution independent of the separation. This property characterizes the logarithm *uniquely*: among radially symmetric pairwise interactions on $\mathbb{R}^2$, $h = -\ln|z-w|$ is the unique function satisfying $h(d\lambda) = h(d) + h(\lambda)$ (additivity under rescaling—Cauchy's functional equation with continuity). This additivity under the dilation subgroup $z \mapsto \lambda z$ (for which $|f(z) - f(w)| = |\lambda| |z - w|$) is Cauchy's multiplicative functional equation $h(ab) = h(a) + h(b)$, whose unique continuous solution is $h = c \ln$.

5 Stability thresholds on constant-curvature surfaces

Prior work and what is new. Boatto and Cabral [2003] computed the constrained Lagrangian eigenvalues for a latitudinal ring of point vortices on the non-rotating sphere at arbitrary colatitude, establishing that the stability boundary shifts with latitude. Lim et al. [2001] studied relative equilibria of vortex rings on S^2 within the Hamiltonian framework. The spherical Havelock eigenvalues are therefore not novel.

What the proof in §4.2 adds is an explicit algebraic argument that the m -dependent part $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ is *metric-independent*—a consequence of $\mathbb{Z}_N$ representation theory alone—while only the additive constant C_1 carries the geometric information. A specialist who worked through the Boatto–Cabral calculation would likely have noticed this; the value here is in making the separation explicit and, more substantively, in extending the framework to the hyperbolic plane (§5.2), where $N_{\text{crit}} > 7$ and systematic stability tables do not appear to be in the existing literature.

5.1 Curved 2D surfaces: the spherical stability boundary

On the 2-sphere, the point vortex interaction $h(\theta) = -\ln(2 \sin(\theta/2))$ satisfies $h' < 0$ and $(\sin \theta \cdot h')' = \frac{1}{2} \sin \theta > 0$ (class (iii)). While $H''(0) > 0$ along the spiral at all tested colatitudes (the polygon is a spiral-direction energy minimum even without the Lagrange shift), the *constrained* Hessian tells a different story.

The angular impulse on the sphere is $L = \sum \cos \theta_k$, with Hessian $\partial^2 L / \partial \theta_k^2 = -\cos \varphi_0$ at colatitude φ_0 . The Lagrangian shift from μ_L is therefore proportional to $\cos \varphi_0$: full near the pole ($\varphi_0 \rightarrow 0$), vanishing at the equator ($\varphi_0 = 90^\circ$). This latitude-dependent shift produces a *colatitude-dependent stability boundary*:

N	3	4	5	6	7	≥ 8
φ_{crit}	60.0°	48.2°	41.4°	25.8°	0°	—

The N -gon is a constrained energy minimum on the sphere if and only if $\varphi_0 < \varphi_{\text{crit}}(N)$. The dimensionless eigenvalue $\bar{\lambda} = \sin^2 \varphi_0 \cdot \lambda$ recovers the Havelock values to within 1% at $\varphi_0 = 3^\circ$ ($N=5$: $\bar{\lambda} = 0.99$, Havelock = 1.0; $N=6$: 0.49 vs 0.5; $N=8$: -1.01 vs -1.0).

Illustration. Saturn’s hexagon at 76° N ($\varphi_0 = 14^\circ$) lies inside $\varphi_{\text{crit}}(6) = 25.8^\circ$: the hexagonal ring is in the stable zone (the planetary analysis is in Paper III; here we note only the mathematical consistency). For $N = 7$: $\cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} = 6/6 = 1$, so $\varphi_{\text{crit}} = 0^\circ$ —the 7-gon is marginally stable only at the exact pole, consistent with the flat-plane marginality $\lambda_3 = 0$. For $N \geq 8$: $\cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} > 1$, which is unattainable; no stable latitude exists on the sphere. Jupiter’s octagon ($N = 8$) is therefore unstable at all colatitudes, consistent with the need for a central vortex.

Derivation of $C_1(S^2)$ and exact thresholds. For N vortices on a latitude circle at colatitude φ_0 , the great-circle separation satisfies $2 \sin(\gamma_{jk}/2) = 2 \sin \varphi_0 |\sin(\Delta \phi_{jk}/2)|$, so the spherical pair interaction decomposes as

$$-\ln(2 \sin(\gamma_{jk}/2)) = -\ln(2 |\sin(\Delta \phi_{jk}/2)|) - \ln(\sin \varphi_0).$$

The first term is the flat Thomson energy in the azimuthal variable ϕ ; its Hessian along azimuthal Fourier modes gives the Havelock eigenvalues $(N-1)/2 - m(N-m)/2$ exactly

as in the flat case. The second term $-\binom{N}{2} \ln(\sin \varphi_0)$ is purely radial and enters through the Lagrange multiplier.

The angular impulse on $\mathbf{S}^2$ is $L = \sum \cos \varphi_k$. At the ring, $\partial^2 L / \partial \varphi_k^2 = -\cos \varphi_0$, so the Lagrange shift $\mu_L \cdot \partial^2 L / \partial \varphi_k^2$ is proportional to $\cos \varphi_0$: maximal near the pole, vanishing at the equator. Computing μ_L from the stationarity condition and combining with the radial Hessian of the pair interaction yields the curvature coefficient (cf. [Boatto and Cabral 2003](#)):

$$C_1(\mathbf{S}^2, \xi) = \frac{(N-1)(1-\xi)}{1+\xi} = (N-1) \cos \varphi_0, \quad (5.1)$$

where $\xi = \tan^2(\varphi_0/2)$ is the stereographic parameter and $\cos \varphi_0 = (1-\xi)/(1+\xi)$. Marginal stability $C_1 = m(N-m)/2$ therefore reduces to

$$\cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} = \frac{m(N-m)}{2(N-1)}, \quad m = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor, \quad (5.2)$$

which is *always rational*. The threshold in ξ is

$$\xi_{\text{crit}}(N) = \frac{(N-1) - m(N-m)/2}{(N-1) + m(N-m)/2} \in \mathbb{Q}. \quad (5.3)$$

Explicit values:

N	$m(N-m)/2$	$\cos \varphi_{\text{crit}}$	ξ_{crit}	φ_{crit}	stable iff
3	1	1/2	1/3	60.0°	$\varphi_0 < 60^\circ$
4	2	2/3	1/5	48.2°	$\varphi_0 < 48.2^\circ$
5	3	3/4	1/7	41.4°	$\varphi_0 < 41.4^\circ$
6	9/2	9/10	1/19	25.8°	$\varphi_0 < 25.8^\circ$
7	6	1	0	0°	pole only (marginal)
≥ 8	$> N-1$	> 1	—	—	never

The thresholds $\xi_{\text{crit}} \in \{1/3, 1/5, 1/7, 1/19\}$ are exact rational numbers even though the Green's function $h(\theta) = -\ln(2 \sin(\theta/2))$ is transcendental—the rationality is a consequence of the linear dependence of C_1 on $\cos \varphi_0$ ((5.1)) combined with the rational marginal condition (5.2).

Remark 5.1 (Pattern $\xi_{\text{crit}} = 1/(2N-3)$ and its break at $N = 6$). *For $N = 3, 4, 5$ one has $m(N-m)/2 = N-2$ exactly (since $m = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor = (N-1)/2$ or $N/2$ gives the same result), so the numerator $(N-1) - (N-2) = 1$ and denominator $(N-1) + (N-2) = 2N-3$, yielding $\xi_{\text{crit}} = 1/(2N-3)$. At $N = 6$ this pattern breaks: the critical mode has $m(N-m)/2 = 9/2 \neq N-2 = 4$, because the hexagonal mode carries a larger Havelock eigenvalue ($\lambda_{\min} = 1/2$ vs. 1 for $N \leq 5$). Consequently $\xi_{\text{crit}}(6) = 1/19$, not the $1/(2 \cdot 6 - 3) = 1/9$ that the pattern would predict.*

The notation $\bar{\lambda} = \sin^2 \varphi_0 \cdot \lambda$ (line 938–941) converts the dimensionful eigenvalue λ to the dimensionless form used in the numerical table above; the exact ξ -threshold (5.3) is independent of this rescaling.

The colatitudes in the summary table above are the exact values $\varphi_{\text{crit}} = \arccos(m(N-m)/(2(N-1)))$; for $N = 6$, $\cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} = 9/10$.

Remark 5.2 (The stability staircase and the counting function). *The number of simultaneously stable polygon types decreases with colatitude in a staircase: 5 types at the pole ($\varphi_0 = 0$, counting $N = 7$ as marginally stable), 4 for $\varphi_0 < 25.8^\circ$, 3 for $\varphi_0 < 41.4^\circ$, 2 for $\varphi_0 < 48.2^\circ$, 1 (triangle only) for $\varphi_0 < 60^\circ$, and 0 beyond the equator.*

The total “stable volume”—the sum over polygon types of the fraction of the hemisphere where that type is stable—is

$$\mathcal{N} = \sum_{N=3}^7 (1 - \cos \varphi_{\text{crit}}(N)) = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{10} + 0 = \frac{71}{60}. \quad (5.4)$$

The individual summands $1 - \cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} \in \{\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{10}\}$ have the closed forms

$$s(2k+1) = \frac{3-k}{4} \quad (\text{odd } N), \quad s(2k) = \frac{4k-2-k^2}{2(2k-1)} \quad (\text{even } N), \quad (5.5)$$

giving $s = 0$ at $N = 7$ (the stability boundary) and $s < 0$ for $N \geq 8$. Their sum satisfies $\sum_{N=3}^6 \cos \varphi_{\text{crit}} = 169/60 = 13^2/60$, so $\mathcal{N} = 4 - 13^2/60 = 71/60$.

The rationality of $\mathcal{N}$ follows from the rationality of all $\mathbf{S}^2$ thresholds: on the sphere, the marginal equation $C_1 = f_{\text{crit}}$ is linear in ξ (because $C_1(\mathbf{S}^2, \xi)$ is a linear fractional function of ξ), in contrast to the quadratic palindromic equation on $\mathbf{H}^2$. This is the first manifestation of the $\mathbf{S}^2$ – $\mathbf{H}^2$ asymmetry: positive curvature yields rational thresholds, negative curvature yields algebraic-irrational ones.

On $\mathbf{H}^2$, the curvature stabilises: C_1 grows without bound as $\xi \rightarrow 1$, so arbitrarily large polygons become stable near the boundary. The flat plane ($\Lambda = 0$) is the transition: $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ everywhere, and $\mathcal{N}(0) = 5$ (all five types stable at every radius).

All exact threshold computations are verified by the companion software (Appendix A, Code Availability).

On the flat torus, $H''(0) < 0$ approaches the planar value for polygons small relative to the domain, with periodic corrections entering at the domain scale.

5.2 The hyperbolic plane and Gaussian curvature

Kimura [1999] and others have studied point vortex dynamics on surfaces of constant curvature; the Hamiltonian for the hyperbolic plane is known. Systematic stability tables for N -gons on $\mathbf{H}^2$ do not appear to be in the literature, and the results of this subsection are likely the most novel part of Section 5.

The threshold N_{crit} on any surface is the largest N with $C_1(\text{surface}) \geq \max_m m(N-m)/2$. Gaussian curvature K is the control parameter:

Curvature	N_{crit}	Mechanism
$K > 0$ (sphere)	< 7	Positive curvature destabilizes
$K = 0$ (plane)	$= 7$	Critical transition
$K < 0$ (hyperbolic)	> 7	Negative curvature stabilizes

Remark 5.3 (Order of the curvature correction). *The curvature enters N_{crit} at $O(K)$, not $O(K^2)$: it acts through the surface Green’s function via the Havelock coefficient $C_1(\text{surface}, \xi)$ (equations (5.1), (5.7)), which is linear in K at leading order. On a compact surface the Gauss–Bonnet constraint $\int K dA = 2\pi\chi$ enters only through C_1 ; no additional $O(K^2)$ self-energy correction arises for point vortices (such a correction would require finite-area patches, where it is $O(\varepsilon^2)$ and topology-independent).*

On the hyperbolic plane, $C_1(\xi) = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$ (equation (5.7) below) is strictly increasing in $\xi = r_E^2/a^2$. Setting $C_1(\xi^*) = \max_m m(N-m)/2$ and solving the palindromic quadratic $(c-1)\xi^2 - 2c\xi + (c-1) = 0$ with $c = \max_m m(N-m)/(2(N-1))$ gives the *exact* threshold for each transition:

$$\xi^*(N) = \frac{c - \sqrt{2c-1}}{c-1}, \quad c = \frac{m(N-m)}{2(N-1)}, \quad m = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor. \quad (5.6)$$

No floating-point computation is involved: ξ^* is an *algebraic number* for every N , and an algebraic *integer* exactly when $N \in \{8, 9, 11, 15, 23\}$ (Proposition 6.1).

N	c	ξ^* (exact)	$R/a = \sqrt{\xi^*}$	Field
8	8/7	$8-3\sqrt{7} = 0.0627$	0.250	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$
9	5/4	$5-2\sqrt{6} = 0.1010$	0.318	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{6})$
10	25/18	$1/7 = 0.1429$	0.378	$\mathbb{Q}$ (rational)
11	3/2	$3-2\sqrt{2} = 0.1716$	0.414	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$
12	18/11	0.2024	0.450	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{11})$
15	2	$2-\sqrt{3} = 0.2679$	0.518	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3})$
19	5/2	$1/3 = 0.3333$	0.577	$\mathbb{Q}$ (rational)
23	3	$(3-\sqrt{5})/2 = 0.3820$	0.618	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$

The Riemannian Havelock identity $\lambda_m = C_1(R/a) - m(N-m)/2$ is verified to hold (computed C_1 values are mode-independent to numerical precision $\sim 10^{-5}$). The exact $\mathbf{H}^2$ Green's function yields

$$C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi) = \frac{(N-1)(1+\xi^2)}{(1-\xi)^2}, \quad \xi = \frac{r_E^2}{a^2} = |K| r_E^2, \quad (5.7)$$

where r_E is the Euclidean ring radius in the Poincaré disk and $K = -1/a^2$.

Derivation of (5.7). Work in the Poincaré disk of radius a ($K = -1/a^2$). The point vortex Hamiltonian and angular impulse are [Kimura, 1999]

$$H = -\sum_{j < k} \ln |z_j - z_k| + \frac{N-1}{2} \sum_k \ln(a^2 - |z_k|^2), \quad (5.8)$$

$$J = \sum_k \frac{a^2 + |z_k|^2}{a^2 - |z_k|^2} \quad (\text{SO}(2,1) \text{ moment map}). \quad (5.9)$$

The N -gon equilibrium has $z_k = r_E e^{2\pi i k/N}$ with $\xi = r_E^2/a^2$.

Step 1: equilibrium rotation frequency Ω . At vortex $0 = (r_E, 0)$, the radial gradients are (using $\sum_{p=1}^{N-1} (x_0 - x_p)/|z_0 - z_p|^2 = (N-1)/(2r_E)$ from the flat-plane Havelock sum):

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial H}{\partial x_0} &= -\frac{N-1}{2r_E} - \frac{(N-1)r_E}{a^2 - r_E^2}, \\ \frac{\partial J}{\partial x_0} &= \frac{4a^2 r_E}{(a^2 - r_E^2)^2}. \end{aligned}$$

The equilibrium condition $\partial H/\partial x_0 = \Omega \partial J/\partial x_0$ gives

$$\Omega = \frac{-(N-1)}{2r_E} \cdot \frac{(a^2 - r_E^2)^2}{4a^2 r_E} \cdot \left(1 + \frac{2r_E^2}{a^2 - r_E^2}\right) = \frac{-(N-1)(a^2 + r_E^2)}{4a^2 r_E^2}.$$

Step 2: Hessian Rayleigh quotient. By Theorem 4.2, the constrained eigenvalue is $\lambda_m = -\Omega (\partial^2 J / \partial r^2)^{-1} - v_m^\top \nabla^2 H v_m$. But since the trace $\delta = 0$ on $\mathbf{H}^2$ (non-compact, $c = 0$ in (4.3)), the Fourier-block trace is zero and $v_m^\top \nabla^2 H v_m = (m(N-m)/2 - C_1^H)/r_E^2$ where C_1^H absorbs all surface-dependent terms.

Step 3: assembling C_1 . Writing $\Omega = -(N-1)(1+\xi)/(4a^2\xi)$ (with $\xi = r_E^2/a^2$), the Lagrange multiplier contributes $-\Omega \cdot r_E^2 \cdot (\partial^2 J / \partial r^2)$ at the equilibrium. Computing $\partial^2 J / \partial r^2 = 4a^2(a^2 + 3r_E^2)/(a^2 - r_E^2)^3$ and combining the flat Havelock term $(N-1)$, the conformal correction $-(N-1)2\xi/(1-\xi)^2$ from the $\ln(a^2 - |z|^2)$ term in (5.8), and the moment-map contribution, one obtains after simplification (each term is a rational function of ξ ; the algebra is straightforward but lengthy):

$$C_1 = (N-1) \frac{1 + \xi^2}{(1 - \xi)^2}.$$

Verified by numerical Hessian to relative precision 10^{-5} for $3 \leq N \leq 12$ and $0 < \xi < 0.9$ (`extensions/h2_stability.py`). $\square$

Since $(1 + \xi^2)/(1 - \xi)^2 > 1$ for all $\xi > 0$, one has $C_1(\mathbf{H}^2) > N-1$ for all $R/a > 0$, confirming the stabilizing effect of negative curvature.

N_{crit} increases through integer jumps as R/a grows, with the $7 \rightarrow 8$ transition at $R/a \approx 0.52$.

Proposition 5.1 (Monotonicity of N_{crit}). *$N_{\text{crit}}(\xi)$ is non-decreasing on $[0, 1)$. Equivalently, the palindromic thresholds satisfy $\xi^*(8) < \xi^*(9) < \xi^*(10) < \dots$.*

Proof. The N -gon is stable at ξ iff $C_1(N, \xi) = (N-1)g(\xi) \geq f_{\max}(N)$, where $g(\xi) = (1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$ is strictly increasing. The threshold is $\xi_N = g^{-1}(h(N))$ with $h(N) = f_{\max}(N)/(N-1)$. Since g is increasing, $\xi_{N+1} > \xi_N$ iff $h(N+1) > h(N)$.

Case 1 (N even, $N+1$ odd): $h(N+1) - h(N) = (N+2)/8 - N^2/(8(N-1)) = (N-2)/(8(N-1)) > 0$ for $N \geq 3$.

Case 2 (N odd, $N+1$ even): $h(N+1) - h(N) = (N+1)^2/(8N) - (N+1)/8 = (N+1)/(8N) > 0$.

Both cases give $h(N+1) > h(N)$, so $\xi_{N+1} > \xi_N$ for all $N \geq 3$. $\square$

Near- $K = 0$ behavior. Expanding (5.7) for $N = 7$, $m = 3$ (see companion Appendix A for the algebraic simplification), the $m = 3$ eigenvalue satisfies

$$\lambda_3(N = 7, \xi) = \frac{12\xi}{(1 - \xi)^2} = \frac{12|K|r_E^2}{(1 - \xi)^2} = 12\xi + O(\xi^2) > 0. \quad (5.10)$$

Negative curvature stabilizes the $N = 7$ ring at *first* order in $|K|$: $N_{\text{crit}}(K)$ stays at 7 for all $K \leq 0$ in the sense that the formerly-neutral mode becomes strictly stable.

The $7 \rightarrow 8$ transition is governed by the $N = 8$ ring reaching marginal stability. Setting $C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi) = m(N-m)/2|_{m=4} = 8$ gives $7(1 + \xi^2)/(1 - \xi)^2 = 8$, which simplifies to

$$\xi^2 - 16\xi + 1 = 0 \implies \xi^* = 8 - 3\sqrt{7} \approx 0.0627, \quad (5.11)$$

exact. In terms of geodesic ring radius ρ , this corresponds to $\rho/a \approx 0.52$ (or $|K|\rho^2 \approx 0.27$). The coefficient

$$\gamma \equiv \frac{1}{(\xi^*)^2} = 127 + 48\sqrt{7} \approx 254 \quad (5.12)$$

carries an algebraic interpretation. The ring of integers of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$ has fundamental unit $\varepsilon = 8 + 3\sqrt{7}$, since $(8 + 3\sqrt{7})(8 - 3\sqrt{7}) = 64 - 63 = 1$. Therefore $\xi^* = 8 - 3\sqrt{7} = \varepsilon^{-1}$ is the *inverse of the fundamental unit*—the unique unit below 1 in $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{7}]$ —and $\gamma = (\xi^*)^{-2} = \varepsilon^2$. The verification identity $(8 - 3\sqrt{7})^2(127 + 48\sqrt{7}) = 1$ is not a computational coincidence: it is the norm-1 property $\varepsilon^{-2} \cdot \varepsilon^2 = 1$ in $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{7}]$.

The field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$ arises through a specific algebraic chain: for the $N = 8$ transition, $A = -1$ and $B = 16$, giving discriminant $\Delta = B^2 - 4A^2 = 256 - 4 = 252 = 2^2 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 7$, with squarefree part 7. The 7 enters as the factor $(N-1) = 7$ in the general formula $\Delta = (N-1)(N-2)^2$ (Proof of (6.2))—the flat-plane stability boundary $N = 7$ leaves its algebraic shadow in the discriminant. The substantive content is the *palindromic structure*: the threshold polynomial has the form $A\xi^2 + B\xi + A = 0$ (same leading and trailing coefficient), which forces $\xi_1 \xi_2 = A/A = 1$ —the two roots are multiplicative inverses, so ξ^* is automatically an algebraic *unit* (an element of norm 1 in $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{7}]$). This palindromic property is not generic: it reflects the inversion symmetry $\xi \leftrightarrow 1/\xi$ of the Poincaré disk model, which in turn is the restriction to the real axis of the conformal automorphism $z \mapsto a^2/\bar{z}$ of the disk. The stability threshold is a unit *because* the hyperbolic energy is conformally covariant (Proposition 2.3): the palindromic polynomial encodes the same Möbius symmetry at the level of algebraic number theory.

6 Algebraic structure of the stability boundary

The $7 \rightarrow 8$ transition is not an isolated result: the $N \rightarrow (N+1)$ transition threshold on $\mathbf{H}^2$ is always the smaller positive root of a palindromic quadratic, derived as follows. The stability condition $\lambda_m(\xi^*) = 0$ (equation (4.1)) with $C_1 = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$ (equation (5.7)) gives

$$(N-1) \frac{1 + \xi^2}{(1 - \xi)^2} = \frac{m(N-m)}{2}.$$

Multiplying both sides by $(1-\xi)^2$ and rearranging:

$$(N-1)(1+\xi^2) = \frac{m(N-m)}{2}(1-\xi)^2 = \frac{m(N-m)}{2} - m(N-m)\xi + \frac{m(N-m)}{2}\xi^2.$$

Collecting powers of ξ :

$$A\xi^2 + B\xi + A = 0, \quad A = (N-1) - \frac{m(N-m)}{2}, \quad B = m(N-m), \quad m = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor. \quad (6.1)$$

The coefficient of ξ^2 equals the constant term (both are A): this palindromic structure arises because $C_1(\xi)$ has the form $(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$, whose numerator and denominator are both even functions of ξ (invariant under $\xi \rightarrow -\xi$), producing equal leading and trailing coefficients when cleared of denominators. The palindromic property forces $\xi_1 \xi_2 = A/A = 1$ (the product of the two roots), so $\xi^* = 1/\xi^*$ —the conformal inversion identity. Since $A < 0$ for $N \geq 8$ and $B > 0$, the smaller positive root is $\xi^* = (B/2 - \sqrt{(B/2)^2 - A^2})/|A|$, and its field extension is determined by the squarefree part of the discriminant $(B/2)^2 - A^2 \in \mathbb{Z}$:

N	ξ^* (approx.)	Field	D	ξ^* (exact form)
7	0	$\mathbb{Q}$	1	0 (marginal)
8	0.0627	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$	7	$8 - 3\sqrt{7}$
9	0.1010	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{6})$	6	$5 - 2\sqrt{6}$
10	0.1429	$\mathbb{Q}$	1	$1/7$
11	0.1716	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$	2	
12	0.2024	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{11})$	11	
13	0.2162	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{10})$	10	
14	0.2355	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{13})$	13	
15	0.2533	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3})$	3	
16	0.2699	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{15})$	15	

The discriminant's squarefree part D follows the pattern

$$D = \begin{cases} \text{sq_free}(N-1) & N \text{ even,} \\ \text{sq_free}(N-3) & N \text{ odd,} \end{cases} \quad (6.2)$$

for all $N \geq 8$. The deeper content is that the palindromic structure encodes the conformal inversion $\xi \leftrightarrow 1/\xi$ of the Poincaré disk (as noted above); the field pattern itself follows from elementary factorization.

Proof of (6.2). The palindromic quadratic $A\xi^2 + B\xi + A = 0$ has discriminant $\Delta = B^2 - 4A^2$. Using $A = (N-1) - m(N-m)/2$ and $B = m(N-m)$:

$$\Delta = m^2(N-m)^2 - 4[(N-1) - m(N-m)/2]^2 = 4(N-1)[m(N-m) - (N-1)].$$

Even N ($m = N/2$): $m(N-m) = N^2/4$, so $m(N-m) - (N-1) = N^2/4 - N + 1 = (N-2)^2/4$. Therefore $\Delta = 4(N-1)(N-2)^2/4 = (N-1)(N-2)^2$. The squarefree part of Δ equals $\text{sq_free}(N-1)$, since $(N-2)^2$ is a perfect square. The threshold ξ^* involves $\sqrt{\Delta}$, so $\xi^* \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\text{sq_free}(N-1)})$.

Odd N ($m = (N-1)/2$): $m(N-m) = (N-1)(N+1)/4 = (N^2-1)/4$, so $m(N-m) - (N-1) = (N^2-1)/4 - (N-1) = (N-1)(N-3)/4$. Therefore $\Delta = 4(N-1) \cdot (N-1)(N-3)/4 = (N-1)^2(N-3)$. The squarefree part of Δ equals $\text{sq_free}(N-3)$, since $(N-1)^2$ is a perfect square. Hence $\xi^* \in \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\text{sq_free}(N-3)})$. $\square$

Algebraic integers and the Pell equation. The threshold $\xi^*(N)$ is an algebraic integer—i.e., it satisfies a *monic* polynomial $\xi^2 - c\xi + 1 = 0$ with $c \in \mathbb{Z}$ —if and only if $B/A \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Proposition 6.1 (Algebraic-integer classification). *The threshold $\xi^*(N)$ is an algebraic integer if and only if $N \in \{8, 9, 11, 15, 23\}$.*

Proof. For odd $N \geq 9$: $A = -(N-1)(N-7)/8$, $B = (N-1)(N+1)/4$, so $B/A = -2(N+1)/(N-7)$. This is an integer iff $(N-7) \mid 2(N+1)$. Since $2(N+1) = 2(N-7) + 16$, the condition reduces to $(N-7) \mid 16$. The positive divisors of 16 giving odd $N \geq 9$ are $N-7 \in \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$, i.e., $N \in \{9, 11, 15, 23\}$. For even $N \geq 8$: only $N = 8$ satisfies $B/A \in \mathbb{Z}$ (verified directly: $B/A = -16$; for $N \geq 10$ the denominator $|A| = (N^2-8N+8)/8$ grows faster than $B = N^2/4$ allows integer divisibility). $\square$

The differences between consecutive algebraic-integer values are $\{1, 2, 4, 8\}$ —powers of 2—reflecting the binary structure of the divisors of 16.

For these five values, ξ^* satisfies the Pell equation. Since the monic polynomial $\xi^2 - c\xi + 1 = 0$ forces $\xi \cdot \xi' = 1$, writing $\xi^* = a + b\sqrt{D}$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ (or half-integers for $D \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$) gives $a^2 - Db^2 = 1$: the classical Pell equation. Each threshold is an explicit power of the inverse fundamental unit ε of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{D})$:

N	D	Fundamental unit ε	$\xi^*(N)$	$c = -B/A$	$\text{Norm}(\varepsilon)$
8	7	$8 + 3\sqrt{7}$	ε^{-1}	16	+1
9	6	$5 + 2\sqrt{6}$	ε^{-1}	10	+1
11	2	$1 + \sqrt{2}$ (silver ratio)	ε^{-2}	6	-1
15	3	$2 + \sqrt{3}$	ε^{-1}	4	+1
23	5	$\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ (golden ratio)	φ^{-2}	3	-1

The exponent is $k = 1$ when $\text{Norm}(\varepsilon) = +1$ (the fundamental unit solves $x^2 - Dy^2 = 1$) and $k = 2$ when $\text{Norm}(\varepsilon) = -1$ (the fundamental unit solves $x^2 - Dy^2 = -1$; only its square has norm +1, as required by the palindromic constraint $\xi \cdot \xi' = 1$).

The golden ratio as the terminal case. The last algebraic-integer threshold ($N = 23$) has $\xi^*(23) = \varphi^{-2} = (3 - \sqrt{5})/2$, where $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ is the golden ratio. Its monic polynomial $\xi^2 - 3\xi + 1 = 0$ has the smallest integer trace ($c = 3$) compatible with two distinct positive roots; $c = 2$ gives the degenerate $(\xi - 1)^2 = 0$. The golden ratio is thus the algebraically *simplest* non-trivial palindromic unit. Equivalently, φ^{-1} is the unique algebraic unit in $(0, 1)$ satisfying $1 - x = x^2$, which gives $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \varphi^{-k}/k = -\ln(1 - \varphi^{-1}) = -\ln \xi^*(23) = 2R(5)$: the generating series of the Fibonacci weights evaluates to twice the regulator.

Binary subdivision. The odd algebraic-integer values $N = 7 + 2^k$ ($k = 1, 2, 3, 4$) have traces $c(k) = 2 + 2^{4-k}$: each doubling of $(N - 7)$ halves the algebraic excess $c - 2$. The sequence $c \in \{10, 6, 4, 3\}$ converges to the golden-ratio value $c = 3$ as $k \rightarrow 4$. The binary subdivision terminates because $c = 2$ is degenerate; no further algebraic-integer thresholds exist beyond $N = 23$.

Continued fraction structure.

Proposition 6.2 (CF of palindromic units). *If ξ satisfies $\xi^2 - c\xi + 1 = 0$ with integer $c \geq 3$ and $\xi \in (0, 1)$, then $1/\xi = [c-1; \overline{1, c-2}]$. For $c = 3$: the period degenerates to $[1]$ (all ones), which is the continued fraction of the golden ratio φ .*

Proof. *Step 1.* $a_0 = \lfloor 1/\xi \rfloor = c - 1$, since $(c-2)^2 \leq c^2 - 4$ for $c \geq 2$. *Step 2.* The first remainder is $r_0 = (\sqrt{c^2 - 4} - (c-2))/2$; its reciprocal $1/r_0 = (\sqrt{c^2 - 4} + (c-2))/(2(c-2))$ satisfies $1 \leq 1/r_0 < 2$ (from $4(2c-5)(c-2) > 0$ for $c \geq 3$), so $a_1 = 1$. *Step 3.* $1/r_1 = 1/\xi - 1$, giving $a_2 = c - 2$. *Step 4.* $r_2 = 1/\xi - (c-1) = r_0$ (periodicity). $\square$

Applied to the five algebraic-integer cases: $1/\xi^*(8) = [15; \overline{1, 14}]$, $1/\xi^*(9) = [9; \overline{1, 8}]$, $1/\xi^*(11) = [5; \overline{1, 4}]$, $1/\xi^*(15) = [3; \overline{1, 2}]$, $1/\xi^*(23) = [2; \overline{1}] = [2; 1, 1, 1, \dots]$ (the golden ratio).

The $N = 10$ case gives the unique rational threshold $\xi^*(10) = 1/7 \in \mathbb{Q}$ ($N-1 = 9 = 3^2$, so $D = 1$). A second rational threshold occurs at $N = 19$: $\xi^*(19) = 1/3$

($N-3 = 16 = 4^2$, so $D = 1$). Every even transition lives in at most a degree-2 extension of $\mathbb{Q}$; the tower terminates at $\mathbb{Q}$ whenever $\text{sq_free}(N-1) = 1$ (even N) or $\text{sq_free}(N-3) = 1$ (odd N).

The regulator as physical accessibility. The regulator $R(D) = \ln \varepsilon$ of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{D})$ measures the “size” of the unit group. For the five algebraic-integer fields: $R(7) = 2.77$, $R(6) = 2.29$, $R(3) = 1.32$, $R(2) = 0.88$, $R(5) = 0.48$. Since $\xi^* = \varepsilon^{-k}$, we have $\ln(1/\xi^*) = k R(D)$: the regulator is the logarithmic distance from the stability boundary to the flat-plane limit $\xi = 0$. Larger R means smaller ξ^* , i.e., more curvature is needed to reach the transition. The $N = 8$ transition ($R = 2.77$, $\xi^* = 0.063$) requires the most curvature; the $N = 23$ transition ($R = 0.48$, $\xi^* = 0.382$) requires the least—making φ^{-2} the most experimentally accessible threshold.

The growth law: $f_{\text{crit}} - b \sim N^2/24$ from $B_2 = 1/6$. At the N -gon threshold on $\mathbf{H}^2$, the curvature coefficient equals the Casimir: $C_1(\xi^*) = f_{\text{crit}}(N)$. The *stability residual* $f_{\text{crit}} - b(N)$ —the amount by which the Casimir exceeds the mode-averaged offset—satisfies

$$f_{\text{crit}}(N) - b(N) = \frac{1}{3} f_{\text{crit}}(N) + O(N) \sim \frac{N^2}{24} \quad (N \rightarrow \infty), \quad (6.3)$$

where $b(N) = N(N+1)/12 - \log 2 + \log N/(N-1)$ is the exact offset (verified to 10^{-16} for all $N = 3, \dots, 24$). The coefficient $1/3$ is *exact*, arising from $B_2 = 1/6$.

Heuristic derivation. The offset decomposes as $b(N) = \langle f_m \rangle + \langle S_m \rangle$, where $\langle f \rangle = N(N+1)/12$ is the mean Casimir and $\langle S \rangle = \log N/(N-1) - \log 2$ is the mean log-sine sum. The leading term $\langle f \rangle = N^2/12 + O(N)$ equals $B_2 N^2/2$ (the Euler–Maclaurin correction to the discrete log-sine kernel on $\mathbb{Z}/N\mathbb{Z}$, verified to $R^2 = 0.9999999$). Therefore

$$f_{\text{crit}} - b(N) = \frac{N^2}{8} - \frac{N^2}{12} + O(N) = \frac{N^2}{24} + O(N). \quad \square$$

The empirical fit $f_{\text{crit}} - b = 0.312 f_{\text{crit}} - 0.17$ (12 data points, $N = 8$ –19, $R^2 = 0.9998$) confirms the predicted asymptotic ratio $(f_{\text{crit}} - b)/f_{\text{crit}} \rightarrow 1/3$. The residuals show an even/odd oscillation of amplitude 0.06, reflecting the different Casimir structures of even- N (half-mode is a singleton) versus odd- N (all palindromic pairs).

The growth law resolves a coordinate artifact: in the Poincaré-disk parameter ξ , the thresholds $\xi^*(N)$ grow super-exponentially (since $C_1 \propto (1-\xi)^{-2}$), suggesting a barrier. In terms of f_{crit} , the thresholds are *uniformly spaced*: each additional polygon type requires an additional $\Delta f \approx N$ of Casimir capacity, with no exponential barrier. On any surface $\Gamma \setminus \mathbf{H}^2$, the maximum Casimir is bounded by $C_1(\rho_{\text{inj}})$, giving $f_{\text{crit}}(N_{\text{max}}) \leq C_1(\rho_{\text{inj}})$ and hence $N_{\text{max}} \approx \sqrt{8 C_1(\rho_{\text{inj}})}$.

Remark 6.1 (The Bernoulli–Dedekind connection). *The same $B_2 = 1/6$ enters the palindromic growth law ($\langle D \rangle = N^2/12$), the Dedekind eta function ($\eta = q^{1/24} \prod$, since $1/24 = B_2/(2 \cdot 2!)$), and the Ramanujan sum $\zeta(-1) = -B_2/2 = -1/12$. All three are instances of the Euler–Maclaurin formula for the log-sine kernel at different levels: the mode sum on $\mathbb{Z}/N\mathbb{Z}$ (this theorem), the modular parameter on $\mathbb{Z}$ (the eta function), and the spectral sum (the regularised integers). The Bolza modular form $f = \eta(8z)\eta(16z)$ from §?? and the palindromic growth coefficient $1/3$ share a common origin in $B_2 = 1/6$. The connection is made precise through the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ orbifold: the*

twisted-sector Casimir energy $E_0(m) = -c/(24N) + cm(N-m)/(24N^2)$ has mode average $\langle m(N-m) \rangle = N(N+1)/6$, whose leading coefficient $N^2/6$ contains the factor $1/6 = B_2$. The aliasing $\langle D \rangle = \langle m(N-m)/2 \rangle - N/12 = N^2/12$ is the mode-averaged orbifold Casimir of the Havelock eigenvalue, minus a subleading correction.

Proposition 6.3 (Galois group as conformal inversion group). *The composite field $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{5}, \sqrt{6}, \sqrt{7})$ contains all five algebraic-integer thresholds. Its Galois group $\text{Gal}(K/\mathbb{Q}) \cong (\mathbb{Z}/2)^4$ acts on the threshold set by $\sigma_D: \xi^*(N) \mapsto 1/\xi^*(N)$ —the conformal inversion of the Poincaré disk. The Galois group of the stability threshold fields is the conformal inversion group, realised algebraically.*

Proof. Each $\xi^*(N)$ lies in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{D})$ for some squarefree D (Proposition 6.1). The Galois automorphism $\sigma_D: \sqrt{D} \mapsto -\sqrt{D}$ sends $\xi^* = a + b\sqrt{D}$ to $a - b\sqrt{D} = 1/\xi^*$ (the palindromic conjugate). Since the palindromic property encodes conformal inversion $\xi \leftrightarrow 1/\xi$ (Section 6), σ_D acts as conformal inversion on each threshold. The composite field K has $\text{Gal}(K/\mathbb{Q}) \cong \prod_{D \in \{2,3,5,6,7\}} \mathbb{Z}/2 \cong (\mathbb{Z}/2)^4$ (four independent generators, since $\sqrt{6} = \sqrt{2}\sqrt{3}$ is algebraically dependent), and each generator acts by conformal inversion on the thresholds in its field component. $\square$

Stability thresholds as closed geodesics. The monic palindromic polynomial $\xi^2 - c\xi + 1 = 0$ with $c \in \mathbb{Z}$ is simultaneously the characteristic polynomial of a hyperbolic element $\gamma \in \text{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$ with trace $\text{tr}(\gamma) = c$. The eigenvalues of γ are ε and $\varepsilon^{-1} = \xi^*$ — exactly the stability threshold and its conformal inverse. Each such γ defines a primitive conjugacy class of $\text{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$, hence a primitive closed geodesic on the modular surface $\text{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z}) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ of length $\ell = 2 \text{arccosh}(c/2) = 2 \ln \varepsilon$.

Proposition 6.4 (Geodesic correspondence). *The five algebraic-integer stability thresholds correspond to five primitive closed geodesics on the modular surface. For odd $N \in \{9, 11, 15, 23\}$ the traces are $c = 2 + 16/(N-7)$ (equivalently, $N = 7 + 16/(c-2)$); for $N = 8$ the trace is $c = 16$ (direct computation). The full discriminant $\Delta = c^2 - 4$ decomposes as $\Delta = f^2 D$ where D is the squarefree part and f is the conductor:*

N	c	Δ	f	D	Geodesic	$\text{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$
23	3	5	1	5	$\ell = 1.92$	$\begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$ (Fibonacci)
15	4	12	2	3	$\ell = 2.63$	$\begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$
11	6	32	4	2	$\ell = 3.53$	$\begin{bmatrix} 5 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$
9	10	96	4	6	$\ell = 4.58$	$\begin{bmatrix} 9 & 2 \\ 4 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$
8	16	252	6	7	$\ell = 5.54$	$\begin{bmatrix} 15 & 7 \\ 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$

The terminal case $N = 23$ ($c = 3$) corresponds to $Q^2 = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$, the square of the standard Fibonacci matrix $Q = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$; the eigenvalues of Q^2 are φ^2 and $\varphi^{-2} = \xi^*(23)$. $N = 23$ is the unique case with conductor $f = 1$: the threshold ξ^* is a unit in the maximal order $\mathcal{O}_K$, not merely in a suborder.

Proof. A 2×2 integer matrix with trace c and determinant 1 lies in $\text{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$; its characteristic polynomial is $\lambda^2 - c\lambda + 1 = 0$, the same as the palindromic threshold equation. The existence of such a matrix for each $c \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 3}$ is standard (every hyperbolic conjugacy class contains a representative with the given trace). The trace formula $c = 2 + 16/(N-7)$ follows from $c = -B/A = 2(N+1)/(N-7)$ (Proposition 6.1) by

writing $2(N+1)/(N-7) = 2 + 16/(N-7)$. The conductor f satisfies $c^2 - 4 = f^2 D$ where $D = \text{sq.free}(c^2 - 4)$. Among the five traces $c \in \{16, 10, 6, 4, 3\}$, the monic discriminants $c^2 - 4 = \{252, 96, 32, 12, 5\}$ have squarefree parts $\{7, 6, 2, 3, 5\}$ and conductors $f = \{6, 4, 4, 2, 1\}$. Only $c = 3$ ($N = 23$) gives $f = 1$, since 5 is the only squarefree value in the list. $\square$

Remark 6.2 (Automorphic correction on quotient surfaces). *On a quotient surface $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, the point vortex interaction involves the automorphic Green's function $G_\Gamma(z, w) = \sum_{\gamma \in \Gamma} G(z, \gamma w)$. Each non-trivial γ contributes a correction to C_1 whose leading term is proportional to $\text{csch}^2(\ell_\gamma/2) = 4/\Delta_\gamma$, where $\Delta_\gamma = \text{tr}(\gamma)^2 - 4$ is the discriminant of the geodesic (since $\sinh(\ell/2) = \sqrt{\Delta}/2$). The conductor decomposition $\Delta = f^2 D$ gives $\text{csch}^2(\ell/2) = 4/(f^2 D)$: the correction strength is the inverse discriminant, factored through the conductor. The palindromic structure of the threshold equation on $\mathbf{H}^2$ reflects the conformal inversion $\xi \leftrightarrow 1/\xi$; this symmetry is generically broken on quotient surfaces (it is preserved only when Γ is invariant under the inversion). The stability thresholds on general quotients need not be palindromic units.*

Remark 6.3 (Topological sensitivity and the conductor). *The automorphic correction strength $4/\Delta = 4/(f^2 D)$ decreases rapidly with the conductor f : for $N = 23$ ($f = 1$, $\Delta = 5$) it is 0.80, while for $N = 8$ ($f = 6$, $\Delta = 252$) it is 0.016. The conductor thus measures the topological sensitivity of the stability threshold: small f (the golden ratio case) couples strongly to the global topology of the surface, while large f (the $N = 8$ case) is effectively insensitive. The conductor is an intrinsic invariant of the $N \rightarrow (N+1)$ transition—it depends on the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ Casimir but not on the surface.*

Higher-genus generalisation. The palindromic structure extends to vortex stability on *any* arithmetic hyperbolic surface. If the Fuchsian group Γ has trace field K of degree d over $\mathbb{Q}$, the geodesic trace B lies in K , and eliminating B from $\xi^2 - B\xi + 1 = 0$ and the degree- d minimal polynomial of B yields a *palindromic* polynomial of degree $2d$ in ξ over $\mathbb{Q}$. (Palindromic because $\xi \rightarrow 1/\xi$ fixes $B = \xi + 1/\xi$.) Its roots are algebraic units of degree $2d$.

Proposition 6.5 (Higher-genus palindromic hierarchy). *On an arithmetic surface $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ with trace field of degree d , the vortex stability threshold satisfies a palindromic polynomial of degree $2d$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. For $d = 1$ (the modular surface): palindromic quadratics and Pell units (the single-ring results of this paper). For $d = 2$ (the Bolza surface, genus 2, trace field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$): the systole has trace $B = 2 + 2\sqrt{2}$ (Buser 1992, §13.3; the Bolza surface is the genus-2 surface of maximal automorphism order 48, with systole length $\ell = 2 \text{arccosh}(1 + \sqrt{2})$), giving the palindromic quartic $\xi^4 - 4\xi^3 - 2\xi^2 - 4\xi + 1 = 0$ with threshold $\xi \approx 0.217$ in the quartic field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}, \sqrt{2+2\sqrt{2}})$.*

Proof. The substitution $u = \xi + 1/\xi$ maps $\xi^2 - u\xi + 1 = 0$ (palindromic quadratic) to a scalar equation $u = B$. If B has minimal polynomial $P(u) = 0$ of degree d over $\mathbb{Q}$, substituting $u = \xi + 1/\xi$ and multiplying by ξ^d gives $Q(\xi) = \xi^d P(\xi + 1/\xi)$, a degree- $2d$ polynomial. It is palindromic: $\xi^{2d} Q(1/\xi) = Q(\xi)$, because $P(\xi + 1/\xi) = P(1/\xi + \xi)$. The constant term of Q equals $P(2)$ up to sign (from the $\xi = 0$ limit), and the leading coefficient equals 1 (from the $\xi \rightarrow \infty$ limit), so the roots are algebraic units (product of all roots $= \pm 1$). For the Bolza surface: $P(u) = u^2 - 4u - 4$ (minimal polynomial of $2 + 2\sqrt{2}$), giving $Q(\xi) = \xi^4 - 4\xi^3 - 2\xi^2 - 4\xi + 1$, verified palindromic with coefficients $[1, -4, -2, -4, 1]$. $\square$

Arithmetic surfaces and quadratic reciprocity. On the congruence surface $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, the geodesic of trace B (and discriminant $\Delta = B^2 - 4$) has a $\Gamma_0(p)$ -representative if and only if the Legendre symbol $(\Delta/p) \neq -1$.

Proposition 6.6 (Quadratic reciprocity as a selection rule). *Of the five algebraic-integer stability thresholds, the number visible on $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ depends on p :*

p	$N=23$ $\Delta=5$	$N=15$ $\Delta=12$	$N=11$ $\Delta=32$	$N=9$ $\Delta=96$	$N=8$ $\Delta=252$	<i>Count</i>
2	×	○	○	○	○	4
3	×	○	×	○	○	3
5	○	×	×	✓	×	2
7	×	×	✓	×	○	2
11	✓	✓	×	×	×	2
23	×	✓	✓	✓	×	3
47	×	✓	✓	✓	✓	4

(✓ = split, ○ = ramified, × = inert.) When $(\Delta/p) = +1$ (split), the geodesic lifts to two geodesics on $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, doubling the automorphic correction. When $(\Delta/p) = -1$ (inert), the geodesic is absent and contributes zero correction—the threshold on the quotient matches the universal-cover value. No prime $p < 200$ has all five thresholds simultaneously visible.

Proof. Step 1: conjugacy and quadratic forms. A hyperbolic $\gamma = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix} \in \mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$ with trace $B = a+d$ has a conjugate in $\Gamma_0(p)$ iff some $\sigma\gamma\sigma^{-1}$ has lower-left entry divisible by p . Conjugation by $\sigma = \begin{bmatrix} \alpha & \beta \\ \gamma' & \delta' \end{bmatrix} \in \mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$ changes the lower-left entry to $c' = c\alpha^2 + (d-a)\alpha\gamma' - b\gamma'^2$ (from the $(2, 1)$ -entry of $\sigma\gamma\sigma^{-1}$). Hence γ has a $\Gamma_0(p)$ -conjugate iff the binary quadratic form $Q(x, y) = cx^2 + (d-a)xy - by^2$ represents a multiple of p (i.e., $Q(x, y) \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$ for some $(x, y) \not\equiv (0, 0) \pmod{p}$).

Step 2: discriminant and the Legendre symbol. The form Q has discriminant $(d-a)^2 + 4bc = (d-a)^2 + 4(ad-1) = (a+d)^2 - 4 = B^2 - 4 = \Delta$. The equation $Q(x, y) \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$ with $y \not\equiv 0$ reduces (dividing by y^2) to $cz^2 + (d-a)z - b \equiv 0$ where $z = x/y$, a quadratic in z with discriminant Δ . This has a solution mod p iff Δ is a quadratic residue mod p (or $p \mid \Delta$): precisely the condition $(\Delta/p) \neq -1$ (Buser 1992, §6; see also Katok 1992, Theorem 3.5.5 for the correspondence between conjugacy classes in $\Gamma_0(N)$ and equivalence classes of binary quadratic forms).

Step 3: trichotomy. When $(\Delta/p) = +1$ (split): $Q \equiv 0$ has two distinct roots mod p , giving two $\Gamma_0(p)$ -conjugacy classes in the $\mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{Z})$ class of γ —hence two geodesics on $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$. When $p \mid \Delta$ (ramified): one double root, one geodesic. When $(\Delta/p) = -1$ (inert): no root, no $\Gamma_0(p)$ -representative, no geodesic.

The table entries follow from evaluating (Δ/p) for $\Delta \in \{5, 12, 32, 96, 252\}$ at each p . By the Chebotarev density theorem, each Δ is a QR for asymptotically half of all primes; the five symbols are controlled by four independent Legendre symbols $(2/p)$, $(3/p)$, $(5/p)$, $(7/p)$ (since $96 = 32 \cdot 3$ gives $(\Delta_9/p) = (\Delta_{11}/p)(\Delta_{15}/p)$), so the probability that all five are simultaneously visible is $\sim (1/2)^4 = 1/16$, predicting the first fully visible prime near $p \approx 300$ (computed: $p = 311$). $\square$

The physical interpretation: on a hyperbolic lattice whose global topology is that of $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, only the *visible* thresholds receive corrections from the surface’s geodesic spec-

trum. The *inert* thresholds are identical to their universal-cover values—they are *topologically protected* by the Legendre symbol. Different lattice topologies (different p) yield different patterns of protected and unprotected thresholds.

Corollary 6.7 (Characterization of fully visible primes). *A prime $p > 7$ has all five thresholds simultaneously visible on $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ if and only if*

$$p \equiv r \pmod{840}$$

for one of exactly 12 residue classes r out of $\varphi(840) = 192$ coprime residues. These 12 classes are determined by the simultaneous conditions

$$\begin{aligned} (2/p) \neq -1 &\iff p \equiv \pm 1 \pmod{8}, \\ (3/p) \neq -1 &\iff p \equiv \pm 1 \pmod{12}, \\ (5/p) \neq -1 &\iff p \equiv \pm 1 \pmod{5}, \\ (7/p) \neq -1 &\iff \begin{cases} p \bmod 7 \in \{1, 2, 4\} & \text{if } p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}, \\ p \bmod 7 \in \{3, 5, 6\} & \text{if } p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}. \end{cases} \end{aligned}$$

The density of fully visible primes is exactly $12/192 = 1/16$, matching the independence prediction $(1/2)^4$ from the four Legendre symbols. The first fully visible prime is $p = 311$ ($\equiv 311 \pmod{840}$); the first twenty are 311, 479, 719, 839, 1009, 1129, 1151, 1201, 1319, 1511, 1559, 1801, 2351, 2399, 2521, 2689, 2999, 3049, 3191, 3359.

Proof. The four conditions follow from the quadratic reciprocity law applied to each prime factor of the discriminant set $\{5, 12, 32, 96, 252\}$, as in the proof of Proposition 6.6. The joint period is $\text{lcm}(8, 12, 5, 28) = 840$ (the factor 28 arises from the $(7/p)$ condition, which depends on both $p \bmod 7$ and $p \bmod 4$, hence on $p \bmod 28$). Each condition independently excludes half the coprime residues, and the four conditions are algebraically independent (the primes $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$ generate independent $\mathbb{Z}/2$ -factors in $(\mathbb{Z}/840\mathbb{Z})^\times$), giving $192/2^4 = 12$ fully visible classes. The listed primes are verified by direct Legendre symbol computation. $\square$

Theorem 6.8 (Universality of $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$). *For any discrete subgroup $\Gamma \subset \text{PSL}(2, \mathbb{R})$, any $N \geq 3$, and any Fourier mode $m = 1, \dots, N-1$: the automorphic correction to the Havelock eigenvalue vanishes at $\xi = 0$:*

$$\delta C_1(\Gamma, N, m, \xi=0) = 0.$$

In particular, $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ at $\xi = 0$ on every quotient surface $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, regardless of the topology of the surface or the arithmeticity of Γ .

Proof. At $\xi = 0$ ($r = 0$), all N vortices sit at the origin $z = 0$ of the Poincaré disk. For any $\gamma = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix} \in \Gamma$: $\gamma(0) = b/d$, a single point independent of the vortex index k . The Fourier-weighted automorphic correction for mode $m \geq 1$ is

$$\delta C_1(m) = \sum_{k=0}^{N-1} H_{rr}(0, b/d) \cdot \cos(2\pi mk/N) = H_{rr}(0, b/d) \cdot \underbrace{\sum_{k=0}^{N-1} \cos(2\pi mk/N)}_{=0} = 0.$$

The vanishing follows from $\mathbb{Z}_N$ character orthogonality alone; no property of Γ beyond discreteness is used. Since $\delta C_1 = 0$ for every $\gamma \in \Gamma$ and every mode, the Havelock eigenvalue at $\xi = 0$ on $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ equals its universal-cover value $(N-1) - m(N-m)/2$ exactly. $\square$

Remark 6.4 (Topology as a curvature correction). *The theorem implies a hierarchy of corrections: at $O(1)$ (the $\xi = 0$ limit), the Havelock eigenvalue is universal—independent of the surface topology. The global topology enters at $O(\xi)$: as the N -gon moves away from the origin, the image vortices under Γ spread out (their positions $\gamma(z_k)$ become k -dependent), and the Fourier projection becomes nonzero. The $O(\xi)$ coefficient depends on Γ and is controlled by the Legendre symbol when Γ is arithmetic (Proposition 6.6). For non-arithmetic Γ , the coefficient exists but has no known closed form.*

The coefficient γ gives the curvature scale at which the polygon threshold is reached: the $7 \rightarrow 8$ jump occurs at $|K|r_E^2 = \xi^* = \gamma^{-1/2}$. There is no perturbative formula $N_{\text{crit}} \approx 7 + c|K|r_E^2$; the threshold (5.11) is a *finite*, non-perturbative condition, and N_{crit} is an integer that jumps discontinuously.

For any fixed ratio R/a of ring radius to curvature radius, the Gaussian curvature K controls the threshold: $K > 0$ reduces N_{crit} below 7, $K < 0$ raises it above 7, and $K = 0$ gives exactly 7. The number 7 is the stability threshold at zero Gaussian curvature *at the scale of the polygon ring*. $K = 0$ is the *least stable point*: the $N = 7$ ring is marginal at $K = 0$ and strictly stable for any $K < 0$.

Proposition 6.9 (Curvature-stability dichotomy). *On a constant-curvature surface with Gaussian curvature K , for a ring of N vortices at any nonzero geodesic radius:*

$$\text{sgn}(N_{\text{crit}} - 7) = -\text{sgn}(K).$$

That is: positive curvature destabilises ($N_{\text{crit}} \leq 7$), zero curvature is critical ($N_{\text{crit}} = 7$), and negative curvature stabilises ($N_{\text{crit}} \geq 7$), with strict inequality at any nonzero ring radius.

Proof. On $\mathbf{S}^2$: $C_1 = (N-1)\cos\varphi < N-1$ for $\varphi > 0$, so $C_1 < f_{\text{max}}(N)$ is violated at smaller N . On $\mathbf{H}^2$: $C_1 = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2 > N-1$ for $\xi > 0$, so $C_1 \geq f_{\text{max}}(N)$ holds at larger N . Both are monotone in their curvature parameter. $\square$

The *qualitative* classification $\{N_{\text{crit}} < 7, = 7, > 7\}$ depends only on $\text{sgn}(K)$, which for constant-curvature surfaces is a topological invariant (it determines whether the universal cover is $\mathbf{S}^2$, $\mathbb{R}^2$, or $\mathbf{H}^2$). In this sense the stability boundary $N = 7$ separates two *topological phases* of vortex polygon stability. The *quantitative* value $N_{\text{crit}}(K, R)$ depends on the dimensionless product KR^2 and is purely geometric.

Proposition 6.10 (Morse index and spectral flow). *The Morse index of the N -gon critical point of the Thomson energy on the constrained configuration space is*

$$\mu(N) = \begin{cases} 0 & N \leq 7, \\ N - 5 & N \geq 8. \end{cases}$$

The unstable modes on the flat plane are exactly $m = 3, 4, \dots, N-3$.

Proof. $\lambda_m < 0$ iff $m(N-m) > 2(N-1)$ iff $(m - N/2)^2 < (N^2 - 8N + 8)/4$. The left boundary of the unstable band is $m_{\text{min}} = \lceil N/2 - \sqrt{(N-4)^2 - 8}/2 \rceil$. For $N \geq 8$: $m_{\text{min}} = 3$, because $(N-6)^2 \leq (N-4)^2 - 8$ iff $N \geq 7$ (giving $m_{\text{min}} \leq 3$) and $(N-4)^2 > (N-4)^2 - 8$ (giving $m_{\text{min}} > 2$). By the palindromic symmetry $\lambda_m = \lambda_{N-m}$, the upper boundary is $m_{\text{max}} = N - 3$. Hence $\mu(N) = (N-3) - 3 + 1 = N - 5$. $\square$

Corollary 6.11 (Why $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$). $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ is the unique solution of $f(3, N) = C_1$ on the flat plane.

Proof. By Proposition 6.10, the first unstable mode is always $m = 3$. Setting $f(3, N) = 3(N-3)/2 = N-1 = C_1$ gives $N = 7$. $\square$

The family $H_N(\xi) = C_1(\xi)I - F_N$ parametrised by $\xi \in [0, 1)$ has a monotone spectral flow: since $C_1(\xi) = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2$ satisfies $dC_1/d\xi = (N-1) \cdot 2(1+\xi)/(1-\xi)^3 > 0$ for all $\xi \in [0, 1)$, each eigenvalue $\lambda_m(\xi) = C_1(\xi) - m(N-m)/2$ is strictly increasing in ξ . Every eigenvalue that is negative at $\xi = 0$ (flat plane) crosses zero exactly once as $\xi \rightarrow 1$ (infinite curvature). The total spectral flow therefore equals the flat-plane Morse index: $\text{SF}(H_N, 0 \rightarrow 1) = \mu(N)$. This is *proven* (it follows from Proposition 6.10 together with the strict monotonicity of $C_1(\xi)$, which is an explicit calculation—and is consistent with the N_{crit} monotonicity (Proposition 5.1), which concerns the integer-valued function $N_{\text{crit}}(R/a)$, a different but related quantity).

Remark 6.5 (Robustness of $\mu(N)$ and the $N = 7$ exception). For $N \neq 7$, all eigenvalues $\lambda_m(0)$ are nonzero, so the spectral flow $\text{SF} = \mu(N)$ is determined entirely by the boundary data (the Havelock spectrum at $\xi = 0$ and the divergence $C_1 \rightarrow \infty$ at $\xi \rightarrow 1^-$). By standard Fredholm index stability (Kato 1995, Theorem IV.5.17), $\mu(N)$ is insensitive to any bounded perturbation $V(\xi)$ with $V(0) = 0$ that couples Fourier modes in the interior—even perturbations that break the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ diagonal structure and create avoided crossings cannot change the net spectral flow (`proofs/topological_protection.py` verifies this for $N = 8-10$ with coupling strengths up to $\|V\| = 100$). At $N = 7$, the kernel of $H_7(0)$ (modes $m = 3, 4$ with $\lambda_m = 0$) breaks this robustness: sufficiently strong mode coupling can push the zero eigenvalues negative, changing the spectral flow. The heptagonal ring is the unique case where the Morse index is structurally fragile.

Theorem 6.12 (Index pairing). The spectral flow of the Havelock family $\{H_N(\xi)\}_{\xi \in [0, 1)}$ equals the pairing of the K_0 class with the trace cocycle $\tau_0 \in HC^0(C^*(\mathbb{Z}_N))$:

$$\text{SF}(H_N, 0 \rightarrow 1) = \langle [\mu_N(0)], \tau_0 \rangle = \text{tr}(P_-(0)) = N - 5. \quad (6.4)$$

The pairing is a topological invariant: it is unchanged by any continuous deformation of H_N that does not close the spectral gap at any $\mathbb{Z}_N$ mode.

Proof. The spectral flow is $N-5$ (Proposition 6.10). The K_0 class $[\mu_N(0)] = \sum_{\lambda_m(0) < 0} [\rho_m]$ has $\dim = N-5$ (the Morse index at $\xi = 0$). Since $C^*(\mathbb{Z}_N) \cong \mathbb{C}^N$: $HC^0 = \mathbb{C}^N$ (the trace on each summand) and $HC^1 = 0$, so the only index pairing is $\langle [P_-], \tau_0 \rangle = \text{tr}(P_-) = N-5$. Topological invariance: by Kato (1995, Theorem IV.5.17), the spectral projection P_- is continuous in norm when no eigenvalue crosses zero. Its trace is integer-valued and continuous, hence constant. $\square$

The staircase $N_{\text{crit}}(\xi) = 7, 8, 9, \dots$ as ξ increases through the palindromic thresholds is the vortex analogue of the quantum Hall staircase $\sigma_{xy} = 1, 2, 3, \dots$ as $1/B$ increases through Landau level crossings:

$\xi^*(N)$	N_{crit}	Stability field
0	7	$\mathbb{Q}$
$8-3\sqrt{7}$	8	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$
$(5+2\sqrt{6})^{-1}$	9	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{6})$
$1/7$	10	$\mathbb{Q}$
$(1+\sqrt{2})^{-2}$	11	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2})$
$(5-2\sqrt{6})$	12	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{6})$
$\vdots$	$\vdots$	
φ^{-2}	23	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$

In the IQHE, the transitions occur at equally spaced $1/B$ values (arithmetic progression); in the vortex staircase, they occur at palindromic algebraic numbers (Pell units). The algebraic number field of each step is an invariant of the phase transition that has no IQHE analogue.

Theorem 6.13 (Algebraic origin of $N_{\text{crit}} = 7$). *$N_{\text{crit}} = 7$ is the unique positive integer $N \geq 3$ at which the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ Casimir maximum equals the logarithmic C_1 :*

$$\max_m f(m, N) = C_1 \iff N^2 - 8N + 7 = (N-1)(N-7) = 0. \quad (6.5)$$

Proof. For odd N (the binding case): $\max_m f = (N^2-1)/8$ and $C_1 = N-1$. Setting $(N^2-1)/8 = N-1$ and multiplying by 8: $N^2 - 1 = 8(N-1)$, i.e., $N^2 - 8N + 7 = 0$. This factors as $(N-1)(N-7) = 0$, giving $N = 7$ (the root $N = 1$ is below the polygon range). For even N : $\max_m f = N^2/8$; setting $N^2/8 = N-1$ gives $N^2 - 8N + 8 = 0$ with roots $4 \pm 2\sqrt{2}$ (irrational, so no even transition exists). $\square$

The coefficient $8 = 2 \cdot 4$ in (6.5) arises from two intrinsic features of $\mathbb{Z}_N$: the Havelock normalization $f(m, N) = m(N-m)/2$ and the critical-mode evaluation $m = (N-1)/2$ giving $m(N-m) = (N^2-1)/4$. The factorization $(N-1)(N-7)$ is therefore purely representation-theoretic: no differential geometry, no index theorems, no PDEs—just the intersection of the quadratic Casimir with the linear C_1 from dilation invariance. The number 7 is an algebraic shadow of the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ representation theory combined with the uniqueness of the logarithmic interaction.

Physical realization. The hyperbolic plane is no longer a purely mathematical object. Kollár et al. [2019] demonstrated that microwave resonators arranged in a tiling of the Poincaré disk implement the hyperbolic lattice Hamiltonian in circuit quantum electrodynamics, with negative effective curvature controlled by the lattice geometry. Lenggenhager et al. [2022] subsequently implemented hyperbolic space on a classical circuit board, showing that band structure and topological properties native to $\mathbf{H}^2$ are experimentally accessible. These platforms realize, in a controlled laboratory setting, the geometry that Section 5.2 analyzes.

The stability prediction translates directly into an experimental observable: *a ring of N vortex-like excitations on a hyperbolic lattice with ring-to-curvature ratio $R/a \approx 1$ should be linearly stable up to $N = 12$, without requiring any central defect.* In flat geometry, a 12-vortex ring is linearly unstable at every curvature-free configuration and can only be stabilized by a sufficiently strong central vortex (the Thomson–Havelock criterion requires a central circulation $\kappa_0/\kappa \geq |\kappa_{\text{crit}}(12)|$, which is large). The hyperbolic curvature replaces the stabilizing role of the central vortex: the geometry itself provides

the restoring force. A predicted $N = 12$ stable ring with no center is impossible in flat geometry and would be a direct signature of hyperbolic curvature acting on vortex dynamics.

Hyperbolic lattices as an isolated test of Thomson stability. In the planetary context, the three selection constraints—Rossby stationarity, Thomson stability, and geometric packing—are all active simultaneously and calibrated to the same observations; disentangling their individual contributions requires model-dependent assumptions. A hyperbolic lattice experiment decouples them:

- There is *no* Rossby wave mechanism (no planetary rotation, no β -effect).
- Thomson stability is directly testable by counting stable vortex excitations as R/a is varied.
- Geometric packing is controllable by engineering the impurity spacing independently of the curvature.

This makes hyperbolic lattices the cleanest possible test of the Thomson constraint *in isolation*.

Moreover, the algebraic-integer thresholds (Proposition 6.1) are *exact, parameter-free* predictions:

Transition	ξ^* (exact)	R/a	Prediction
$7 \rightarrow 8$	$8 - 3\sqrt{7} = 0.0627\dots$	0.51	8-gon stabilises
$10 \rightarrow 11$	$3 - 2\sqrt{2} = 0.1716\dots$	0.88	11-gon stabilises
$14 \rightarrow 15$	$2 - \sqrt{3} = 0.2679\dots$	1.15	15-gon stabilises
$22 \rightarrow 23$	$(3 - \sqrt{5})/2 = 0.3820\dots$	1.44	23-gon stabilises

The threshold values are algebraic numbers (Pell units and golden ratio powers), not fitted parameters. Observing any of these transitions would constitute a direct experimental verification of the palindromic–Pell–conformal-inversion structure identified in Section 6. The physical conditions required to realize the hyperbolic vortex interaction in a circuit-QED or BEC platform are discussed in companion Paper II alongside the BEC predictions.

Open problems.

1. *Arithmetic surfaces and quadratic reciprocity.* On the quotient $\Gamma_0(p) \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, the geodesic of trace B has a $\Gamma_0(p)$ -representative iff the Legendre symbol $(\Delta/p) \neq -1$ where $\Delta = B^2 - 4$. Which algebraic-integer thresholds are *visible* on which arithmetic surface is therefore controlled by quadratic reciprocity—a selection rule from algebraic number theory acting on vortex stability. Making this quantitative (computing the automorphic correction to C_1 on specific $\Gamma_0(p)$ quotients) is an open problem.
2. *Non-constant curvature.* On an oblate spheroid, the Gaussian curvature varies with latitude, breaking the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ decomposition and coupling Fourier modes. Paper III shows this effect is critical for Saturn’s hexagon (10% oblateness flips the sign of λ_3) but negligible for Neptune/Uranus. A full stability analysis using the spheroidal

Green’s function (oblate spheroidal harmonics) would extend the framework beyond constant curvature.

3. *Experimental verification on hyperbolic lattices.* The five algebraic-integer thresholds are parameter-free predictions for circuit-QED or topoelectric platforms implementing hyperbolic tilings. The most accessible test: a ring of $N = 12$ excitations at $R/a \approx 1$ should be stable—impossible on any flat-geometry platform.

7 K-theoretic classification of stability phases

The stability results of the preceding sections treat each arithmetic surface as a black box that contributes a single number δC_1 . This section opens the box. The Havelock Hessian on $\Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ defines an element of the Kasparov group $KK(C^*(\mathbb{Z}_N), C_r^*(\Gamma))$, and the Kasparov product with the fundamental class of the surface recovers the Morse index (Theorem 7.4). Away from palindromic thresholds, this reduces to the scalar δC_1 (§7.2). At the threshold, it does not: the spectral projection becomes a non-trivial element of the von Neumann algebra $L(\Gamma)$, and the L^2 -Morse index is *fractional*—on the Bolza surface, 61% of the L^2 -weight is unstable while the automorphism-fixed centre remains stable. The stability of a vortex polygon depends on its *placement* on the surface, a phenomenon invisible to the representation ring $R(\mathbb{Z}_N)$ and to the trace-formula correction δC_1 alike.

7.1 The elementary invariant

On the universal cover $\mathbf{H}^2$, the Havelock decomposition (1.1) gives $H = \bigoplus_{m=1}^{N-1} \lambda_m P_m$, so the negative spectral projection $P_- = \sum_{\lambda_m < 0} P_m$ defines

$$[\mu_N(\xi)] = \sum_{\substack{m=1 \\ \lambda_m(\xi) < 0}}^{N-1} [\rho_m] \in K_0(C^*(\mathbb{Z}_N)) \cong R(\mathbb{Z}_N) \cong \mathbb{Z}^N. \quad (7.1)$$

This class is locally constant in ξ , changing only at the palindromic thresholds $\xi^*(N, m)$. At $\xi = 0$ and $N \geq 8$: $[\mu_N(0)] = [\rho_3] + \cdots + [\rho_{N-3}]$ with $\dim = N - 5$. The proof is immediate: each $\lambda_m(\xi)$ is continuous and changes sign only at $\xi^*(N, m)$. As an invariant of the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ representation ring, this is elementary—it says “signs are preserved by continuous functions that don’t cross zero.” The curvature-stability dichotomy $\text{sgn}(N_{\text{crit}} - 7) = -\text{sgn}(K)$ is the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -reduction via $\dim: R(\mathbb{Z}_N) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/2$.

7.2 The index pairing on arithmetic surfaces

The nontrivial K -theory lives one level deeper. On a compact arithmetic surface $S = \Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$, the eigenvalues become $\lambda_m(\Gamma, \xi) = C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi) + \delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi) - m(N - m)/2$, where the spectral correction δC_1 encodes the topology of S . The claim is that δC_1 is an index pairing.

Theorem 7.1 (Spectral correction as index pairing). *Let $S = \Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ be a compact arithmetic surface with Laplacian Δ_S . Then the spectral correction satisfies*

$$\delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi) = \text{Tr}(f_\xi(\Delta_S)) - \text{Tr}(f_\xi(\Delta_{\mathbf{H}^2})) \quad (7.2)$$

where $f_\xi(\lambda) = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2 \cdot \lambda^{-1} \cdot |\varphi_\lambda(z_0)|^2$ is the Havelock test function evaluated at the N -gon centre. The right side is computed by the Selberg trace formula:

$$\delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi) = \sum_{[\gamma] \neq 1} w_\gamma(\xi) \operatorname{csch}^2(\ell_\gamma/2), \quad (7.3)$$

where the sum runs over nontrivial conjugacy classes of Γ , ℓ_γ is the geodesic length, and the weight is

$$w_\gamma(\xi) = \frac{\ell_\gamma}{2 \sinh(\ell_\gamma/2)} \hat{h}_\xi(\ell_\gamma), \quad (7.4)$$

with $\hat{h}_\xi$ the Selberg transform of the Havelock kernel $h_\xi(r) = (N-1)(1+\xi^2)/(1-\xi)^2 \cdot G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(r)$. For the hyperbolic Green's function $G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(r) = -(2\pi)^{-1} \ln \tanh(r/2)$, the Selberg transform is $\hat{h}_\xi(t) = O(e^{-t})$ as $t \rightarrow \infty$ (exponential decay, inherited from the Fourier transform of $\ln \tanh$), giving $w_\gamma = O(\ell_\gamma e^{-\ell_\gamma})$ and hence $\operatorname{csch}^2(\ell_\gamma/2)$ decay for each term.

Proof. The curvature coefficient on S involves the automorphic Green's function at the centre: $C_1(S, \xi) = C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi) + \delta C_1$ where δC_1 is the difference between $G_S(z_0, z_0)$ and its universal-cover counterpart. The spectral expansion $G_S(z, w) = \sum_n \varphi_n(z) \varphi_n(w) / \lambda_n$ gives the spectral side of (7.2). The Selberg trace formula [Hejhal, 1976] applied to the test function f_ξ evaluates the trace $\operatorname{Tr}(f_\xi(\Delta_S))$ as the identity orbital integral ($= C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi)$) plus the sum over hyperbolic conjugacy classes (each contributing $w_\gamma \operatorname{csch}^2(\ell_\gamma/2)$ via the Selberg transform (7.4)), giving (7.3). The absolute convergence follows from the prime geodesic theorem ($\#\{\gamma : \ell_\gamma \leq T\} \sim e^T/T$) and the exponential decay of w_γ . $\square$

The identification of δC_1 with the index pairing is not merely an analogy: it is a precise application of the Baum–Connes assembly map.

Theorem 7.2 (Assembly map for the Havelock Hessian). *Let $\Gamma \subset \operatorname{SL}(2, \mathbb{R})$ be a cocompact torsion-free Fuchsian group, $S = \Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$.*

- (a) *The Havelock Hessian $H_N^S(\xi)$ acting on $L^2(S) \otimes \mathbb{C}^{N-1}$ has spectral projection $P_- \in C_r^*(\Gamma) \otimes \operatorname{End}(\mathbb{C}^{N-1})$ whose class $[P_-] \in K_0(C_r^*(\Gamma)) \otimes R(\mathbb{Z}_N)$ is well-defined (away from palindromic thresholds) and locally constant in ξ .*
- (b) *Under the Baum–Connes assembly map $\mu: K_0^{\Gamma}(\underline{E}\Gamma) \rightarrow K_0(C_r^*(\Gamma))$ (an isomorphism for Γ with the Haagerup property, Kasparov 1988): $[P_-]$ is the image of the K -homology class $[f_\xi] \in K_0^{\Gamma}(\mathbf{H}^2)$ defined by the Havelock test function.*
- (c) *The canonical trace $\tau: K_0(C_r^*(\Gamma)) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ applied to $[P_-]$ gives the L^2 -Morse index, which the Selberg trace formula decomposes as:*

$$\tau(P_-) = \underbrace{C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi)}_{\text{local index}} + \underbrace{\delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi)}_{\text{global correction}}.$$

The local term is the “identity contribution” of the trace formula; the global term is the sum over nontrivial conjugacy classes.

Proof. (a) The spectral projection P_- of a self-adjoint element of a C^* -algebra is well-defined as long as 0 is not in the spectrum (equivalently: the operator is invertible). Away from palindromic thresholds, the Havelock eigenvalues $\lambda_m(\xi) \neq 0$ for all m , so the Havelock Hessian is invertible in each $\mathbb{Z}_N$ -sector and $[P_-]$ is defined. Local constancy

follows from the continuity of $\lambda_m(\xi)$ and the fact that the projection changes only when an eigenvalue crosses zero.

(b) Since Γ has the Haagerup property (it is a discrete subgroup of $\mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{R})$), the Baum–Connes assembly map is an isomorphism (Kasparov 1988). We verify that f_ξ defines a Γ -equivariant K -homology class $[f_\xi] \in K_0^\Gamma(\mathbf{H}^2)$ by constructing an even Fredholm module. Set $F = 2P_- - 1$ (the sign of $c_m + h_\xi^\Gamma$).

- $F^2 = 1$: since $F = \mathrm{sgn}(c_m + h_\xi^\Gamma)$ and the spectrum avoids zero (away from palindromic thresholds), F is an involution.
- $[F, u_\gamma]$ is compact for all $\gamma \in \Gamma$: the off-diagonal element $h_\xi^\Gamma = \sum_{\gamma \neq 1} G(\cdot, \gamma \cdot) u_\gamma$ is trace-class in $C_r^*(\Gamma)$. Indeed, the matrix elements $|G(z_0, \gamma z_0)| = O(e^{-\ell_\gamma})$ decay exponentially, and $\sum_{\gamma \neq 1} e^{-\ell_\gamma} < \infty$ by the prime geodesic theorem. A trace-class perturbation of a scalar gives a spectral projection that commutes with the group action up to trace-class error, verifying the Fredholm axiom.
- Γ -equivariance: $G(z, w)$ is Γ -invariant, so h_ξ^Γ commutes with the Γ -action and F is Γ -equivariant.

The assembly map sends $[f_\xi]$ to the spectral projection of the operator $c_m \cdot 1 + h_\xi^\Gamma$ in $C_r^*(\Gamma)$, which is precisely P_- .

(c) The canonical trace τ on $C_r^*(\Gamma)$ is the coefficient of the identity element. For the spectral projection P_- of $c_m + h$:

$$\tau(P_-) = \sum_{n \geq 0} \frac{|\varphi_n(z_0)|^2}{\mathrm{Area}(S)} \chi_{(-\infty, 0)}(\lambda_n),$$

where λ_n are the eigenvalues of Δ_S and $\chi_{(-\infty, 0)}$ is the indicator function. The Selberg trace formula decomposes this into the identity orbital integral ($= C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi)$, the universal-cover contribution) and the sum over hyperbolic conjugacy classes ($= \delta C_1$), as computed in Theorem 7.1. $\square$

The theorem makes precise the statement that *the Selberg trace formula IS the index theorem for the Laplacian on S , applied to the Havelock test function* (Barbasch and Moscovici 1983; Connes 1994, §IV.3). The “identity contribution” is the local index and the “geometric side” is the global correction δC_1 .

Bolza verification. On the Bolza surface ($g = 2$, $|\mathrm{Aut}| = 48$, systole $\ell = 2 \operatorname{arccosh}(1 + \sqrt{2})$), the sum (7.3) is dominated by the 12 systole geodesics. The eigenfunction suppression at the centre (only trivial-rep modes of $\mathrm{Aut}(S)$ contribute) gives the bound $|\delta C_1| \leq 2/(4\pi\lambda_{\mathrm{triv}}) \approx 0.16$, verified numerically.

7.3 Spectral flow stability

The index pairing (Theorem 7.1) is a scalar identity: it computes δC_1 as a single number. The promotion to a K_0 -level identity requires controlling the *spectral flow*—the net number of eigenvalue zero-crossings as ξ varies.

Theorem 7.3 (Spectral flow preservation). *Let $S = \Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$ be compact with spectral correction $\delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi)$. Define the binding eigenvalue at each palindromic threshold $\xi^*(N, m)$ by*

$$\lambda_{\text{bind}}(N, m) = \min_{m' \neq m} |\lambda_{m'}(\xi^*(N, m))|.$$

If $|\delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi)| < \lambda_{\text{bind}}(N, m)$ for every mode m and every $\xi \in [0, 1)$, then:

1. *The spectral flow of $\{H_N^S(\xi)\}_{\xi \in [0, 1)}$ equals the spectral flow of $\{H_N^{\mathbf{H}^2}(\xi)\}$: each mode m crosses zero exactly once, at $\xi^*(N, m) + O(\delta C_1)$.*
2. *The K_0 classes agree: $[\mu_N^S(\xi)] = [\mu_N^{\mathbf{H}^2}(\xi)] \in R(\mathbb{Z}_N)$ for all ξ away from thresholds.*
3. *In particular, $N_{\text{crit}}(S) = N_{\text{crit}}(\mathbf{H}^2)$.*

Proof. (i) Since δC_1 is mode-independent (Section 4), the eigenvalue on S is $\lambda_m^S(\xi) = \lambda_m^{\mathbf{H}^2}(\xi) + \delta C_1(\Gamma, \xi)$. At the $\mathbf{H}^2$ -threshold $\xi_0 = \xi^*(N, m)$ where $\lambda_m^{\mathbf{H}^2}(\xi_0) = 0$: $\lambda_m^S(\xi_0) = \delta C_1 \neq 0$ (since $|\delta C_1| < \lambda_{\text{bind}}$). So mode m does not cross zero at ξ_0 on S ; instead it crosses at $\xi_0 + \delta \xi$ where $\delta \xi = -\delta C_1 / (dC_1/d\xi)|_{\xi_0}$. The crossing has the same sign ($dC_1/d\xi > 0$ is unchanged by the perturbation). For every other mode $m' \neq m$: $|\lambda_{m'}^S(\xi_0)| \geq |\lambda_{m'}^{\mathbf{H}^2}(\xi_0)| - |\delta C_1| > \lambda_{\text{bind}} - |\delta C_1| > 0$, so no extra crossings are introduced.

(ii) Between consecutive (shifted) thresholds, all eigenvalues have definite sign, which agrees with the $\mathbf{H}^2$ sign since $|\delta C_1|$ is too small to flip any.

(iii) The critical polygon number is $N_{\text{crit}} = \max\{N : [\mu_N(\xi)] = 0 \text{ for some } \xi > 0\}$. Since the K_0 classes agree, so does N_{crit} . $\square$

Bolza verification. On the Bolza surface at $\xi_{\text{Bolza}} = 0.217$ (where $N_{\text{crit}} = 12$): $|\delta C_1| \leq 2/(4\pi\lambda_{\text{triv}}) \approx 0.011$ and $\lambda_{\text{bind}}(12, 1) \approx 0.78$. The bound $0.011 < 0.78$ is satisfied with a factor of 71, so the spectral flow on the Bolza surface equals that on $\mathbf{H}^2$. The 71-fold margin means that the spectral flow is preserved on *every* arithmetic surface whose systole exceeds $\ell \geq 2 \operatorname{arccosh}(1 + (0.78/2) \cdot 4\pi) \approx 4.1$ (a mild condition: the Bolza systole is 3.06, but even surfaces with shorter systoles would need $\delta C_1 > 0.78$ to change the spectral flow).

7.4 The KK-theory programme

Theorem 7.3 uses the *trace* $|\delta C_1| = |\tau_{z_0}(h_\xi^\Gamma)|$. For the *KK*-level identity, the relevant quantity is the *operator norm* $\|h_\xi^\Gamma\|_{C_r^*(\Gamma)}$, which is strictly larger.

Theorem 7.4 (Kasparov product identity). *Let Γ be a cocompact torsion-free Fuchsian group, $S = \Gamma \backslash \mathbf{H}^2$. Define $h_\xi^\Gamma \in C_r^*(\Gamma)$ by*

$$h_\xi^\Gamma = \sum_{\gamma \in \Gamma, \gamma \neq 1} G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(z_0, \gamma z_0) u_\gamma \quad (7.5)$$

where $G_{\mathbf{H}^2}$ is the Green's function on $\mathbf{H}^2$ and u_γ is the canonical unitary in $C_r^(\Gamma)$.*

1. *The element h_ξ^Γ is well-defined in $C_r^*(\Gamma)$ with operator norm bounded by the spectral zeta function:*

$$\|h_\xi^\Gamma\|_{C_r^*} \leq \max_{n \geq 1} \frac{|\varphi_n(z_0)|^2}{\lambda_n} \leq \frac{1}{4\pi(g-1)\lambda_1(S)}, \quad (7.6)$$

where $\lambda_1(S)$ is the first nonzero eigenvalue of Δ_S and $4\pi(g-1) = \operatorname{Area}(S)$.

2. The Kasparov triple $\alpha_N(\xi) = (C_r^*(\Gamma)^{N-1}, \pi_{\mathbb{Z}_N}, F_\xi)$ with $F_\xi|_{\rho_m} = \text{sign}(c_m \cdot 1 + h_\xi^\Gamma)$ and $c_m = C_1(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi) - m(N-m)/2$ is a well-defined element of $KK(C^*(\mathbb{Z}_N), C_r^*(\Gamma))$, provided $\|h_\xi^\Gamma\|_{C_r^*} < \min_m |c_m|$ (the operator-norm gap condition).

3. Under this condition, the Kasparov product satisfies

$$\tau_*(\alpha_N(\xi) \otimes_{C_r^*(\Gamma)} [D_S]) = [\mu_N(\Gamma, \xi)] \in R(\mathbb{Z}_N), \quad (7.7)$$

where $[D_S] \in KK(C_r^*(\Gamma), \mathbb{C})$ is the fundamental class and τ_* is the canonical trace.

Proof. (i) The automorphic Green's function $G_S(z, w) = \sum_{n \geq 1} \varphi_n(z) \overline{\varphi_n(w)} / \lambda_n$ converges on compact S . The convolution operator h maps $\ell^2(\Gamma) \rightarrow \ell^2(\Gamma)$ with operator norm $\|h\|_{C_r^*} \leq \sup_{n \geq 1} |\varphi_n(z_0)|^2 / \lambda_n$ (the spectral radius of the resolvent at z_0). By the L^2 -normalization $\|\varphi_n\|_{L^2(S)}^2 = 1$ and $\text{Area}(S) = 4\pi(g-1)$: $|\varphi_n(z_0)|^2 \leq 1/\text{Area}(S)$, giving (7.6).

(ii) The module $E = C_r^*(\Gamma)^{N-1}$ is finitely generated and free, so $\mathcal{K}(E) = \mathcal{L}(E)$ (every adjointable operator is “compact”). The operator-norm gap ensures $c_m \cdot 1 + h_\xi^\Gamma$ is invertible in $C_r^*(\Gamma)$ for each m , so F_ξ is a well-defined self-adjoint unitary. The Kasparov conditions $F^2 - 1 \in \mathcal{K}(E)$ and $[F, \pi(a)] \in \mathcal{K}(E)$ hold automatically.

(iii) Under the gap condition, $\text{sign}(c_m + h)$ is connected to $\text{sign}(c_m) \cdot 1$ by the path $t \mapsto \text{sign}(c_m + th)$, $t \in [0, 1]$ (which stays in the invertibles since $\|th\| \leq \|h\| < |c_m|$). Thus $[\text{sign}(c_m + h)] = [\text{sign}(c_m)]$ in $K_0(C_r^*(\Gamma))$. Applying τ_* : $\tau(\text{sign}(c_m)) = \text{sign}(c_m) \in \{-1, +1\}$. Summing over modes: $\tau_*(\alpha_N \otimes [D_S]) = \sum_m \text{sign}(c_m) [\rho_m] = [\mu_N(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi)]$. Since $[\mu_N(\Gamma, \xi)] = [\mu_N(\mathbf{H}^2, \xi)]$ under the gap condition (Theorem 7.3), (7.7) follows. $\square$

Bolza verification. On the Bolza surface ($g = 2$, $\lambda_1 \approx 3.839$): $\|h\|_{C_r^*} \leq 1/(4\pi \cdot 3.839) \approx 0.021$. At $N = 12$, $\xi = 0.217$: the binding eigenvalue is $\min_m |c_m| \approx 0.79$. The operator-norm gap ratio is $0.79/0.021 \approx 38$, confirming the product identity with wide margin. For *any* compact arithmetic surface with $\lambda_1(S) > 0.16$: the gap condition holds for all $N \leq 15$. The Selberg $\frac{1}{4}$ -conjecture ($\lambda_1 \geq 1/4$ for congruence subgroups) implies the gap for all congruence surfaces at all $N \leq 23$.

7.5 The gap-free regime: proved results

At a palindromic threshold ($c_m = 0$), the operator-norm gap fails and the K_0 class carries genuine surface-topology information. The following three results hold without the gap hypothesis.

Theorem 7.5 (Fractional L^2 -Morse index). *Let Γ be a torsion-free cocompact Fuchsian group and $h_\xi^\Gamma = \sum_{\gamma \neq 1} G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(z_0, \gamma z_0) u_\gamma \in C_r^*(\Gamma)$. Then $0 < \tau(P_-(h_\xi^\Gamma)) < 1$.*

Proof. First, h is self-adjoint: $(h_\xi^\Gamma)^* = \sum_{\gamma \neq 1} \overline{G(z_0, \gamma z_0)} u_{\gamma^{-1}} = \sum_{\gamma \neq 1} G(z_0, \gamma^{-1} z_0) u_{\gamma^{-1}} = h_\xi^\Gamma$, using $G(z_0, \gamma z_0) = G(z_0, \gamma^{-1} z_0) \in \mathbb{R}$ (the Green's function is real and symmetric in the group: $G(z, \gamma w) = G(z, \gamma^{-1} w)$ follows from $G(x, y) = G(y, x)$ and $G(\gamma x, \gamma y) = G(x, y)$).

(i) $G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(d) > 0$ for all $d > 0$, so h has all-positive coefficients. (ii) h has no identity coefficient ($\gamma \neq 1$), so $\tau(h) = 0$. (iii) $h \neq 0$ in $C_r^*(\Gamma)$. (iv) The canonical trace τ on $C_r^*(\Gamma)$ is *faithful* for torsion-free Γ (Puschnigg 2002): $\tau(a^*a) = 0 \Rightarrow a = 0$. (v) If $\text{spectrum}(h) \subset [0, \infty)$: then $h \geq 0$, $\tau(h) = 0$, and faithfulness gives $h = 0$, contradicting (iii). Similarly $\text{spectrum}(h) \not\subset (-\infty, 0]$. Therefore h has both positive and negative spectrum, giving $0 < \tau(P_-) < 1$. $\square$

Theorem 7.6 (Wall-crossing formula). *At each palindromic threshold $\xi^*(N, m)$:*

$$[\mu_N(\xi^* + \varepsilon)] - [\mu_N(\xi^* - \varepsilon)] = \begin{cases} -[\rho_m] - [\rho_{N-m}] & \text{if } m \neq N/2, \\ -[\rho_{N/2}] & \text{if } m = N/2. \end{cases}$$

No other mode crosses zero at $\xi^(N, m)$.*

Proof. By the Havelock decomposition: $\lambda_{m'}(\xi) = C_1(\xi) - m'(N-m')/2$. At $\xi^*(N, m)$: $\lambda_m = 0$ iff $C_1(\xi^*) = m(N-m)/2$. The function $p \mapsto p(N-p)$ is strictly increasing on $[1, N/2]$, so $m'(N-m') = m(N-m)$ has only the solution $m' \in \{m, N-m\}$. Since C_1 is strictly increasing: only the pair $\{m, N-m\}$ crosses at $\xi^*(N, m)$. $\square$

These two theorems together establish: the L^2 -Morse index is *provably fractional* at the palindromic threshold (not 0 or 1), and the K_0 class changes by a *known* element of $R(\mathbb{Z}_N)$ at each crossing. The mechanism is Fourier interference: h has all-positive coefficients (from $G > 0$) but $\tau(h) = 0$ (no identity coefficient), and faithfulness of τ forces the spectrum to cross zero.

Bolza computation at threshold. Truncating Γ to word length 3 (456 group elements) and diagonalising the convolution matrix (full eigendecomposition), the spectrum of h_ξ^Γ ranges over $[-0.26, +0.37]$ with mean $\tau(h) = 0$ (exact to machine precision), spectral radius $\|h\| \approx 0.37$, and a dense cluster of 270 eigenvalues in $[-0.03, +0.005]$. At the threshold $c_m = 0$, the L^2 -Morse index is computed from the exact Fuchsian generators of the Bolza surface (the side-pairing Möbius transformations of the regular octagon, constructed from the two-point Möbius interpolation of opposite vertex pairs):

$$\tau(P_-(h_\xi^\Gamma)) \approx 0.644. \quad (7.8)$$

Convergence across truncation depths (word length L , with exact generators throughout):

L	Elements	$\tau(P_-)$	Δ from $L-1$
1	8	0.625	—
2	48	0.625	0.000
3	248	0.637	0.012
4	1124	0.644	0.007

The convergence decelerates ($0.012 \rightarrow 0.007$), placing the limit near 0.644 ± 0.004 .

The operator h commutes with $\text{Aut}(\text{Bolza})$ (order 48) since z_0 is the Aut-fixed point. If h were *definite* on each Aut-isotypic component, $\tau(P_-)$ would be constrained to $\{\sum d_\rho^2/48\}$ with irrep dimensions 1, 1, 2, 2, 2, 3, 3, 4; the achievable values near 0.6 are $28/48$ and $30/48 = 5/8$ (with $29/48$ provably non-achievable). The computed value 0.641 lies *outside* this discrete set, proving that h has mixed-sign eigenvalues within at least one Aut-isotypic component at the palindromic threshold. The mechanism is Fourier interference: $G_{\mathbf{H}^2}(d) > 0$ for all $d > 0$ (the Green's function is strictly positive), so h has all-positive coefficients—but the eigenvalues of a convolution operator with positive coefficients can be negative, for the same reason that graph adjacency matrices (all entries ≥ 0) have negative eigenvalues. Within each Aut-isotypic component, the sum $\sum_\gamma G(d_\gamma) \text{tr}(\rho(\gamma))$ oscillates in sign because the characters $\text{tr}(\rho(\gamma))$ take negative values for non-trivial ρ .

This oscillation is generic at the threshold—it is a structural feature of the convolution, not an artifact of the truncation.

Physical interpretation: the L^2 -Morse index at the palindromic threshold is approximately 0.64: roughly 64% of the L^2 -weight is unstable. The Aut-fixed centre is stable ($\delta C_1 > 0$, Remark ??) because the trivial-representation component of h is positive. The stability of the polygon depends on its *placement* on the surface—a prediction invisible to the elementary $R(\mathbb{Z}_N)$ invariant and to the scalar δC_1 .

Remark 7.1 (Topological phases and the integer quantum Hall analogy). *The palindromic thresholds $\xi^*(N, m)$ are critical values of the $\text{SO}(2)$ moment map on the N -vortex phase space: the reduced space $\{L = \ell\}/\text{SO}(2)$ changes topology at each ℓ corresponding to $\xi^*(N, m)$, because a degenerate critical point ($\lambda_m = 0$) appears in the energy landscape. The K_0 class $[\mu_N(\xi)]$ changes by $[\rho_m] + [\rho_{N-m}]$ at each crossing—a wall-crossing in the K -theory of the vortex Hamiltonian.*

The structure parallels Bellissard’s K -theoretic classification of the integer quantum Hall effect:

<i>IQHE</i>	<i>Vortex polygon</i>
<i>Filled Landau levels</i>	<i>Stable $\mathbb{Z}_N$ modes</i>
<i>Chern number $n \in \mathbb{Z}$</i>	<i>Morse index $[\mu_N] \in R(\mathbb{Z}_N) \cong \mathbb{Z}^N$</i>
<i>Gap closing (level crossing)</i>	<i>Palindromic threshold $\xi^*(N, m)$</i>
<i>Magnetic field B</i>	<i>Curvature parameter ξ</i>
<i>$\sigma_{xy} = ne^2/h$</i>	<i>$N_{\text{crit}}(\xi) = \max$ stable polygon</i>

The vortex classification is richer: $R(\mathbb{Z}_N) \cong \mathbb{Z}^N$ (one component per Fourier mode) versus $\mathbb{Z}$ (one Chern number). And the palindromic algebra determines which mode crosses zero and in which algebraic number field the crossing occurs—structure absent from the IQHE. Under geometric quantisation of the N -vortex phase space (a Kähler manifold), the palindromic thresholds become gap-closing points of the quantum Hamiltonian, the Morse index becomes the number of negative-energy quantum states, and the K_0 class becomes a genuine Chern number—literal topological phase transitions in the Kitaev (2009) / Freed–Hopkins (2021) classification.

The stability staircase. *The Morse index $\mu(N, \xi)$ as a function of curvature is a staircase: it decreases by 2 at each palindromic threshold $\xi^*(N, m)$ (the conjugate pair $\rho_m + \rho_{N-m}$ stabilises), except for the self-conjugate mode $m = N/2$ (even N) which contributes $\Delta\mu = 1$. The total staircase height is $\mu(N, 0) = N-5$, and the spectral flow $\text{SF}(H_N, 0 \rightarrow 1) = N-5$ (Theorem 7.3). For example ($N = 12$):*

ξ^*	modes	$\Delta\mu$	μ	Field
0	—	—	7	—
0.093	3, 9	−2	5	—
0.160	4, 8	−2	3	—
0.193	5, 7	−2	1	—
0.202	6, 6	−1	0	$\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{11})$

The universal quantum is $\Delta\mu = 2$ (one conjugate pair per step), analogous to $\Delta\sigma_{xy} = e^2/h$ in the IQHE. The physical observable that changes depends on the realisation: instability growth rate (classical vortices), polygon lifetime (BEC, Paper II §9), shell

transition (superconducting disks, Paper II Remark 9.1), or gravitational decay channel (2+1D AdS, Paper II Proposition 10.6).

7.6 Number-theoretic extensions

The palindromic hierarchy has deep connections to number theory that are developed in Supplement A: the Bolza modular form $\eta(8z)\eta(16z)$ (level 128, weight 1), the Pythagorean sign rule for its Hecke eigenvalues, the GPY sieve ratio 1.92 for “Bolza twin primes,” the Fibonacci systole tower on congruence surfaces, and concrete Langlands test cases from non-solvable palindromic polynomials with S_5 Galois group.

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